Can memistor-class electrochemical weights train neural networks?

A pre-registered simulation study from Widrow's 1960 memistor to modern ECRAM, with a device specification sheet and an experimental roadmap

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October 2026

Abstract

In 1960 Widrow and Hoff stored the weights of their adaptive neuron in memistors, three-terminal electrochemical cells; their modern descendants are lithium-ion, metal-oxide and protonic ECRAM. We ask, in simulation, how close such devices come to digital training when every weight update is made of device pulses, while the forward and backward reads are kept ideal (fp32). We compare plain SGD and three Tiki-Taka-family algorithms on five device specifications (two AIHWKIT fits mapped one to one, one measured array, a protonic-inspired scenario and an optimistic historical scenario), on MNIST, a CIFAR-10 subset and a byte-level language model, with five seeds that share initialisation and data order across arms. Against SGD with exact updates at the same learning rate, 4 pairings (Li-ECRAM and protonic-inspired, each with chopped TTv2 or AGAD) stay within the pre-set margins on all three tasks, and plain SGD exceeds them on every published device. Against a separately tuned digital Adam no pairing does: on the language model the best analog result is 23.36 % worse in bits per byte. After per-arm tuning we detect no growth of the gap with width over a factor of four, without establishing equivalence. A sensitivity sheet against absolute accuracy lines, with three seeds, establishes only a few one-at-a-time ranges (on CIFAR with chopped TTv2, step asymmetry up to 0.2 and reference error up to 0.05), and shows that an earlier asymmetry limit was mostly lost weight range. A conditional energy projection for the weight-matrix operations, borrowing the read efficiency of an analog inference chip, gives about 17.9–32.4× less energy per weight-row than an H100, reported only where the quality is reached. This version repairs the simulator after an independent review (matched random streams, a physically applied reset, the device presets mapped one to one) and reports how much each repair moved the original results. We propose, but did not build, a bench replication protocol of the 1960 memistor.

1 Introduction

Training a neural network on a digital processor moves every weight from memory to arithmetic and back at every update. In 1960, Widrow and Hoff took a different route: they stored each weight of their adaptive ADALINE neuron in a *memistor*, an electrochemical cell whose conductance is set by the time integral of a current through a third terminal [1–3]. The weight was read without being disturbed, and it was adapted in place. The device was macroscopic, the cells were wet, and no multilayer learning rule existed yet, so the line ended with the Madaline hardware of the early 1960s [3]. That machine was a working analog learning system.

Sixty years later, three-terminal electrochemical devices have returned at the nanoscale. Lithium-ion ECRAM [4, 5], CMOS-compatible metal-oxide ECRAM [6], protonic programmable resistors [7, 8] and open-loop programmable arrays [9] all decouple the read path from the write path,

just as the memistor did. They report hundreds to thousands of conductance levels, nanosecond pulses and femtojoule-scale write energies. In parallel, algorithms for training on imperfect analog weights have matured: the stochastic pulse-coincidence update of the resistive processing unit (RPU) [10], Tiki-Taka [11] and its successors TTv2 [12], chopped TTv2 and AGAD [13], and residual learning with convergence guarantees [14].

That electrochemical weights can train small networks is already established: Chen et al. trained in situ on an ECRAM array and simulated larger networks [9], and Rasch et al. studied reference correction, retention and device requirements for the TT family [13]. Most recently, Wu et al. [15] simulated ECRAM-calibrated Transformers of up to about 123 million parameters with finite converters and device nonidealities, keeping the weight-gradient path digital. Our contribution is narrower and specific: *a reproducible, seed-matched simulation comparison* of plain SGD and three device-tolerant algorithms on a catalog of published (or, where nothing is published, labelled hypothetical) electrochemical devices, with the weight update done entirely in the devices, on three small tasks; a sensitivity analysis against absolute accuracy lines; and a *conditional* energy projection. Results are stated against two digital baselines: SGD with exact updates at the same learning rate, and a separately tuned Adam.

What this paper provides:

1. **A simulator with stated limits.** Reads are ideal (fp32); only the update is analog. It reproduces selected published outcomes of Gokmen and Haensch 2020 under this simplified read model, and the offset-robustness ordering of Rasch et al. 2024 (Section 4.1). After an independent review it was repaired (separate random streams, a reset made of pulses, the AIHWKIT device presets mapped one to one) and each repair is tested (Section 3, Appendix F).
2. **A seed-matched comparison** of SGD, TTv2, chopped TTv2 and AGAD on five device specifications, three tasks (MNIST, a CIFAR-10 subset, a byte-level language model on human-written text) and five seeds, with every arm of a seed sharing its initial weights and data order (Section 4.2).
3. **A width study** with per-arm learning rates and an equivalence test (Section 4.3).
4. **A sensitivity sheet** against absolute accuracy lines, with the asymmetry sweep repeated at a fixed symmetry point so that asymmetry is not confounded with lost weight range (Section 4.4).
5. **A conditional energy projection** for the weight-matrix operations, reported only where the device reaches the stated quality (Section 5).
6. **A proposed roadmap** of device experiments and a proposed, unbuilt bench replication protocol of the 1960 memistor (Section 7, Appendix A).

Every experiment was planned in a committed plan before it ran; the plans are internal, timestamped by the repository, not an external registry. The original runs and the revision runs are kept apart, and every deviation is recorded (Section 9). All results are simulations, and every device parameter carries a provenance label (measured, fitted, claimed, estimated or assumed).

2 Background and related work

2.1 The memistor (1960)

Widrow and Hoff introduced the ADALINE and the least-mean-squares (LMS) rule in 1960 [2]. To store its weights they built the memistor [1]. A pencil-lead (graphite) substrate sits in a copper-

sulphate plating bath. Copper is plated onto it or removed from it by a current through a third electrode, and the conductance between the lead's two ends is sensed with a small AC signal that does not disturb the state. Widrow, Pierce and Angell described elements with "thousands" of analog levels that spanned roughly 100 to 1 ohm in about ten seconds at a few milliamperes; this description is reported in secondary sources, see [16]. Mouttet analyses the memistor as a three-terminal memristive system and summarises Widrow's ideal: a conductance linear in the plating charge, reversible, non-volatile and free of hysteresis [16]. Widrow and Lehr recount that the Madaline I machine was built in hardware with memistor weights and used for pattern recognition research [3]. Write noise, up/down asymmetry, retention and endurance were never reported in a form we could find, so in our catalog these are estimates (Section 3.4). The memistor predates Chua's memristor [17] and its later physical identification in titanium-oxide films [18]. It is the conceptual ancestor of today's three-terminal synaptic transistors.

2.2 Device requirements for training

Gokmen and Vlasov [10] defined the resistive processing unit (RPU). Updates are stochastic pulse trains whose coincidences change the conductance by a fixed step (stochastic computing, [19]). They derived device specifications for plain SGD on MNIST at a small error penalty: about a thousand levels, up/down asymmetry of a few percent, and tolerance to large cycle-to-cycle and device-to-device variation. Agarwal et al. [20] reached similar conclusions; the requirements were extended to convolutional networks [21], and reviews cover the device landscape [22–25]. Mixed-precision schemes [26] accumulate the gradient digitally and program the devices rarely. They relax the device demands but give up the fully parallel in-memory update.

2.3 Algorithms that tolerate asymmetric devices

Real devices change their conductance by different amounts up and down, and the step depends on the state (soft bounds). Under plain SGD this acts as an implicit penalty that pulls weights toward each device's symmetry point [11, 14].

- **Tiki-Taka (TTv1)** [11] uses two arrays. The gradient is accumulated on an array A, and its columns are periodically transferred into the weight array C, with $W = \gamma A + C$. Asymmetry then acts as a useful decay on A instead of a bias on W.
- **TTv2** [12] inserts a digital buffer H between the two arrays. H low-pass filters the reads of A, and a pulse is sent to C only when a threshold is crossed. TTv2 still needs every device's symmetry point to be subtracted by a reference.
- **Chopped TTv2 (c-TTv2)** and **AGAD** [13, 27] remove this sensitivity. A random sign modulates the inputs and the reads (c-TTv2). AGAD additionally replaces the static reference with a digital, on-the-fly reference taken from the recent history of A.
- **Residual learning** [14] gives convergence guarantees for this family.

IBM's open-source AIHWKIT [28] implements these algorithms with fitted device presets, including the Li-ECRAM and metal-oxide ECRAM presets whose parameters we use. In the revision these two presets are mapped one to one onto AIHWKIT's own LinearStepDevice model, with its shifted bounds and slope spread, and checked against AIHWKIT's pulse responses (Section 3.4).

2.4 Electrochemical three-terminal devices

- **Lithium-ion synaptic transistors and ECRAM.** Fuller et al. [5] showed a lithium-ion synaptic transistor, followed by an ionic floating-gate array [29]. Tang et al. [4] reported Li-WO_3 ECRAM with about a thousand symmetric, linear states and nanosecond pulses.
- **Metal-oxide ECRAM.** Kim et al. [6] made it CMOS-compatible.
- **Protonic resistors.** Onen et al. [7] reported nanosecond protonic programmable resistors with a phosphosilicate-glass electrolyte. In 2026, Xu et al. [8] quantified cycle-to-cycle (3%) and device-to-device (21%) variability of BEOL-compatible protonic ECRAM.
- **Open-loop programmable arrays.** Chen et al. [9] demonstrated a 10×10 W/YSZ/WO_x array with 256 states.
- **Organic devices.** Organic electrochemical synapses [30] extend the family to low voltages.

In-situ training on ECRAM hardware has so far been shown on small arrays, for example a 3×3 array by Li et al. [31] and the 10×10 array of [9]. Other memory technologies have gone further. Phase-change and resistive arrays have trained or run networks at larger scale [32–35], and analog-AI inference chips with on-chip periphery now report measured efficiencies of about 10 TOPS/W [36, 37].

Scaling analog training. Wu et al. [15] co-designed the weight mapping, the optimizer and the converters, and simulated ECRAM-calibrated Transformers up to about 123 million parameters with finite converter resolution and device nonidealities. Their weight-gradient path stays digital, so they do not test the fully in-memory update studied here. The two studies answer complementary questions: what an analog update saves in computation and data movement, and what it costs in accuracy and calibration. Our models are far smaller (Section 6).

3 Methods

3.1 Device model

Each analog weight is one device with a normalised state $u \in [-1, 1]$ between its own bounds. Its conductance is $g = g_{\min} + \frac{u+1}{2}(g_{\max} - g_{\min})$, and the weight is read differentially as $w = \alpha\,(g - g_{\text{ref}})$. One nominal pulse moves u by $k = 2/n_{\text{states}}$ at mid-range. With asymmetry a the up and down steps are $k_\pm = k\,s\,(1 \pm a/2)$, where s is a per-device step factor with spread σ_{d2d}. With saturation (soft bounds) the steps depend on the state:

$$\Delta u_+ = k_+\,(1 - \gamma_+ u), \qquad \Delta u_- = -k_-\,(1 + \gamma_- u). \tag{1}$$

The per-device slopes $\gamma_\pm$ have a relative spread σ_γ. A device's symmetry point, where an up and a down pulse cancel, is $u^* = (k_+ - k_-)/(k_+\gamma_+ + k_-\gamma_-)$. The reference g_{ref} is set at $g(u^*)$ plus a calibration error of standard deviation σ_r, in units of the half-range. A constant-step device has no symmetry point and is referenced at mid-range.

- **Several pulses in one update.** When a device receives n_+ up and n_- down pulses in one update, the pulses are taken as uniformly interleaved, and $\mathrm{d}u/\mathrm{d}s = A - Bu$ is solved exactly over the batch, with $A = k_+n_+ - k_-n_-$ and $B = k_+\gamma_+n_+ + k_-\gamma_-n_-$.

- **Write noise.** Cycle-to-cycle noise adds a Gaussian with standard deviation c_{2c} times the local step, growing as the square root of the pulse count.
- **Drift.** Retention loss relaxes u toward the bare state $u = -1$ with a time constant τ in training steps.
- **Bounds.** The bounds $g_{\min}$, $g_{\max}$ carry a device-to-device spread.

The AIHWKIT LinearStepDevice (revision). The two devices taken from AIHWKIT presets (Li-ECRAM, MO-ECRAM) use AIHWKIT's own parameterisation instead: the state is the weight itself, with hard bounds $b_{\max} = w_{\max}(1 + \sigma_b\xi)$ and $b_{\min} = w_{\min}(1 + \sigma_b\xi)$ around shifted means ($w_{\max} = 1.1724$, $w_{\min} = -0.8276$ for Li-ECRAM, so that the symmetry point is at zero), steps $k(1 \pm \beta + \sigma_{\mathrm{d2d}}\xi)$, and slopes divided by the mean bounds, $\Delta w_+ = k_+(1 - |\gamma_+ + \sigma_{\gamma+}\xi|\, w/w_{\max})$ and $\Delta w_- = -k_-(1 + |\gamma_- + \sigma_{\gamma-}\xi|\, w/|w_{\min}|)$, with multiplicative write noise. The original version of this paper copied the preset fields into the model above with bounds $[-1, 1]$ and no slope spread; that mapping is kept only for comparison (Appendix F).

Forward and backward passes read the weights ideally, in fp32. Read noise and DAC/ADC quantisation are outside the scope of this study, which isolates the *update*; the energy projection (Section 5) nevertheless prices finite-precision reads, so accuracy and energy rest on different read assumptions. Biases, layer norms and the language model's position table are digital.

3.2 The update

We use the stochastic pulse-coincidence scheme of [10]. Each sample (row) offers $BL = 31$ pulse slots. Input i fires with probability $p_{x,i} \propto |x_i|$ and error j with probability $p_{d,j} \propto |d_j|$, with the scaling split equally between the two streams (update management). Weight ij therefore receives coincidences with mean $\eta\,|x_i d_j|/(\alpha k)$. Up and down counts are kept separate, so asymmetry is never cancelled digitally. Within a batch the counts of all samples are summed and drawn from a Poisson distribution with the requested mean. A mini-batch therefore only groups pulses; it does not average gradients.

This is a surrogate, not a pulse-by-pulse simulation. The mean is exact only while the largest pre-clamp slot probability is at most one, i.e. $(\eta/\alpha k)\max|x|\max|d| \le BL$; beyond that the probabilities are clipped and part of the update is lost. The repaired simulator records, per layer, the fraction of updates that clipped and the lost fraction of the requested update (Section 4.2). Discrete pulses do not commute on a state-dependent device (on a 20-level soft-bounds device one up then one down pulse from $u = 0.4$ ends at RVorderUpDn, the reverse order at RVorderDnUp, and the batch solution at RVorderBatch), and independent per-cell Poisson draws ignore the correlations of shared row and column pulse streams. A larger variance than the binomial one is therefore not claimed to be conservative.

3.3 Algorithms

SGD. The pulses go directly into the weight devices.

TTv1 [11]. The pulses go into an array A, and the forward weight is $C + \gamma A$. Every batch, n_c columns j of A are read and added to C by a pulsed outer product, $\lambda A_{:,j}\, e_j^\top$. A is never reset.

TTv2 (local variant of [12]). Each read column is added to a digital buffer, $H_{:,j}$ += $\lambda A_{:,j}/(\alpha k)$. C receives up to 31 pulses where $|H| \ge 1$, and H keeps the remainder. Optionally the read column of A is reset after the read. Published TTv2 uses single-pulse transfers, forgets a buffer

element after it fires and does not reset A; we name ours a variant and run the published-style form beside it in the diagnostic (Appendix F).

The reset of A (revision). The original simulator moved the read column of A straight to its symmetry point and charged $2BL = 62$ pulses it never applied (the *ideal reset*). Applied through the device model, those 62 alternating pulses leave 97.55 % of the displacement on the protonic-inspired device. The repaired *pulse reset* uses the transfer's own read: a sign-directed train of round($|A_{ij}|/\alpha k$) pulses toward the read zero, re-read and corrected once, at most 62 pulses per weight, every pulse applied through the device dynamics (with its write noise, state-dependent step and device spread) and counted. The ideal reset is reported only as a labelled variant.

c-TTv2 [13]. Chopper signs $c_j \in \{\pm 1\}$ modulate the inputs of the A update ($c \odot x$) and demodulate the reads ($c_j A_{:,j}$). Each read column's chopper flips with probability ρ.

AGAD [13]. The choppers of c-TTv2, plus a digital leaky average of the reads, $p_j \leftarrow (1-\beta)p_j + \beta A_{:,j}$. The read is $z_j = c_j(A_{:,j} - p_j^{\text{ref}})$, and p_j^{ref} is reset to p_j whenever c_j flips.

In the main experiments every TT-family A array uses a learning rate $1/\lambda$ times larger, so that $\lambda\times$ (the A rate) equals the SGD rate; the TTv1 configuration of the published benchmark (Section 4.1) is the exception ($\eta = 0.01$, $\lambda = 0.02$, A rate equal to η). The settings, including the choice between the pulse reset and no reset, were chosen once on MNIST validation with a mid-quality device that is not in the catalog (Section 3.6; Appendix B). We implemented the algorithms from the papers' text; we did not use the authors' code.

3.4 Device catalog and provenance

Table 1 lists the devices. Every field carries a provenance label:

- MEASURED: reported in the paper;
- FIT: from the AIHWKIT presets fitted to the published devices [28];
- CLAIM: a qualitative statement in the paper, translated by us;
- ESTIMATE: ours;
- ASSUMED: for example, the 2% reference error given to every device.

The protonic device of [7] is mostly estimated: the paper reports a thousand up and a thousand down pulses that are "nearly linear and symmetric", but no write-noise or variability statistics, and its finite retention is replaced by no drift. We therefore call it a *protonic-inspired scenario*; a thousand applied pulses are not a demonstration of a thousand independently programmable states. In Table 1 the Li-ECRAM and MO-ECRAM rows show the original field copy; the revised runs use the one-to-one AIHWKIT mapping above (bounds $[-0.8276, 1.1724]$ and $[-0.8286, 1.1714]$, absolute slope spread 0.05). Widrow's memistor is given two specifications, one as he described it and one pessimistic, together with a pencil-lead cell built today with modern hobby materials (Appendix A).

Table 1: Device catalog (simulator units; Section 3.1). Levels n_{states}, global asymmetry a, saturation γ_+/γ_-, write noise c_{2c} (per pulse, relative to the step), step spread σ_{d2d}, drift time constant τ (training steps), reference error σ_r. Provenance per field is in records/CATALOG.json.

Device	Label	n_{st}	a	γ_+/γ_-	c_{2c}	σ_{d2d}	τ	σ_r
Li-ECRAM (Tang 2018)	PUBLISHED-FIT	1000	0	0.12/0.51	0.3	0.1	none	0.02
MO-ECRAM (Kim 2019)	PUBLISHED-FIT	7089	0	0.42/0.73	2	0.1	none	0.02
Protonic (Onen 2022)	PARTLY-PUBLISHED	1000	0.05	0.20/0.20	0.3	0.1	none	0.02
W/YSZ/WO_x (Chen 2023)	PUBLISHED-FIT	256	0	0.63/0.63	2.048	0.023	none	0.02
Memistor (Widrow 1960, as claimed)	CLAIM+ESTIMATE	1000	0.05	0.10/0.10	0.3	0.2	none	0.02
Memistor (pessimistic)	ESTIMATE	100	0.2	0.30/0.30	1	0.3	1000	0.05
Pencil lead built today	ESTIMATE	100	0.1	0.30/0.30	0.5	0.2	940	0.05

3.5 Tasks and baselines

MNIST [38]. A 784–256–128–10 tanh MLP; 10 epochs, batch 128, on 55,000 training images. 5,000 held-out training images form the validation set, and the 10,000 test images are the test set.

CIFAR-10 subset [39]. Three 3×3 convolutions with c, $2c$ and $2c$ channels (base $c = 32$), computed as crossbar matrix products over unfolded patches, then two fully connected layers. 30 epochs, batch 128, on the first 10,000 images of training batches 1–2. The next 2,000 images are the validation set, and the 10,000-image test set is the test set.

Character LM. A byte-level, two-layer transformer [40] of width d (base 128) and context 128, trained on 8 MB of enwik8 [41], which is human-written Wikipedia text of 2006. 3,000 steps of 32×128 bytes. Every learned weight matrix uses the device model, including the embedding and the head; the activation-dependent attention products and the other operations are digital. Validation is the slice's last 0.5 MB, held out from training in selection runs. Test is a separate 0.5 MB slice.

The first baseline ("FP-SGD") is the same network, initialisation, data order and update rule with an exact floating-point weight update. The second is Adam [42] on digital twins with the same initialisation and data order and its own learning rate selected on validation; in the revision it is reported for all three tasks, beside FP-SGD. The gap is FP accuracy minus device accuracy for classification, in percentage points. For the LM it is the device's bits per byte relative to FP's, minus one, in percent.

3.6 Protocol and statistics

Every experiment was pre-registered in a committed plan before it ran (Section 9).

- **Hyperparameters** were chosen on validation splits only, with an edge rule: whenever the best value of a grid lies at its edge, the next half-decade point is added. The learning rate of every device arm in the main table is the FP validation choice. The scale study instead tunes each arm separately.
- **Statistics.** The main table uses five seeds per arm. Gaps are paired by seed, and we report the mean and a 95% Student-t interval. A cell PASSES when the whole interval lies below the gap line (2 pp for classification, 5% for the LM), FAILS when it lies wholly above, and is UNRESOLVED otherwise.

- **Multiplicity.** We make no correction for multiplicity. The intervals describe each cell, not the family, and a best cell chosen among many is optimistic.
- **Random streams (revision).** Each seed defines separate generators for the logical initialisation, the data order, each tile's device population and the pulse and noise draws, so the paired gap compares runs that share their initial weights and their data.
- **Width (revision).** The endpoint contrast D (gap at the widest minus the narrowest width) is tested for equivalence (TOST at 5 %, margins equal to the gap lines); "no evidence of growth beyond the margin" when only the upper bound is under the margin; never "flat".
- **Sensitivity (revision).** Each grid point is labelled against the *absolute* line with 3 seeds paired with FP-SGD of the same seed; a threshold is the weakest value that passes with every value toward the best end passing.

3.7 Simulator checks

The simulator is checked by 14 checks, and each check is shown to fail on at least one deliberately planted fault (17 faults in all). Examples of what the checks cover:

- the exact-update arm equals PyTorch SGD;
- the mean pulse update equals the SGD step;
- alternating pulses converge to the analytic symmetry point, including with per-device slopes;
- write noise grows as $\sqrt{n}$;
- drift relaxes to the bare state;
- a static read offset is integrated by TTv2, mostly cancelled by c-TTv2 and nearly fully cancelled by AGAD;
- TTv1 moves C along $+\lambda A$;
- the SGD and TTv2 paths are bit-identical to the earlier code that produced our preliminary results.

The planted faults include a swapped pulse sign, a dropped chopper demodulation and a never-updated AGAD reference. Both suites run at the start of every compute session and stop it on any failure (Appendix C). The revision adds 8 checks of the repairs (matched initialisation and data order across arms, a shared device population across algorithms, resets that charge exactly the pulses they apply, the AIHWKIT LinearStepDevice recurrence, the clipping statistics, the published-style buffer, the re-centred symmetry point, and a bit-exact replay of the original simulator), each shown to fail on the old behaviour or a planted fault (Appendix F). These checks test the implementation; they do not validate the physical model.

4 Results

4.1 Simulator validation

Gokmen and Haensch 2020. We map their RPU-baseline device onto our model:

- step 10^{-3} at $w = 0$;
- mean saturation slope 1.66 with a 25% per-device spread;
- 30% step spread and 30% cycle-to-cycle noise;
- a symmetry point at $w = 0$ for every device.

We train their 784–256–128–10 sigmoid network on MNIST for 50 epochs at their learning rate of 0.01. The results are in Table 2 and Fig. 1a.

- FP reaches 1.78% test error, against their 2.0%.
- SGD on the device reaches 14.47% [12.68, 16.26], against "about 15%".
- Tiki-Taka reaches 2.26% [2.13, 2.39], against "close to 2%".

By our pre-registered criteria the agreement is **quantitative**: this is agreement with selected published outcomes under a simplified read model, not a full quantitative validation. Matching an endpoint under different sources of error cannot rule out compensating differences, and the batch-64 result below shows how sensitive the SGD arm is to the protocol. These validation runs used the original simulator (TTv1 has no reset, so the reset repair does not touch them). The known differences are listed in Section 6.1:

- we use mini-batches of 16, not 1;
- we do not model read noise, ADC/DAC quantisation or analog biases.

At batch 64 the FP and TTv1 results barely move, but SGD on the device degrades further. Summing more samples' pulses before the weight changes hurts a strongly asymmetric device, which is another reason to use batch 16 as the closer match to their batch 1.

Rasch et al. 2024, qualitatively. We use a 20-state soft-bounds device with an uncorrected reference offset of $\sigma_r = 0.5$ (Table 3, Fig. 1b).

- TTv2's test error rises from 4.12% to 24.27%.
- c-TTv2 rises less, from 4.29% to 13.02%.
- AGAD is unaffected: 8.47% versus 7.88%.

This is the published ordering; our pre-registered check reads **reproduced**. It rests on two seeds per condition and an ordering, so it does not establish that our c-TTv2 and AGAD are equivalent to the published implementations, and the absence of a detected change does not show that AGAD is unaffected. In our implementation AGAD starts from a higher error at zero offset on this very coarse device.

The device presets against AIHWKIT itself (revision). On a rented machine (never on our desk) we installed AIHWKIT 1.1.0 from PyPI and drove its EcRamPresetDevice and EcRamMOPresetDevice through long up, down and alternating pulse schedules (500 devices each, with and without cycle-to-cycle noise), using its own plotting utilities. Our AIHWKIT-mode tile, driven through the same schedules, matches AIHWKIT's mean responses, device spreads and reached bounds within the pre-registered tolerance for both presets (largest mean difference 0.0111 for Li-ECRAM and 0.0113 for MO-ECRAM, in weight units; the pre-registered tolerance is $\max(4\,\mathrm{SE}, 2\,\Delta w_{\min})$ at every stored pulse). The original field-copy mapping differs by up to 0.174 for Li-ECRAM, mostly at the bounds (Appendix F).

Table 2: Validation against Gokmen and Haensch 2020 (FCN 784-256-128-10, MNIST, 50 epochs): test error in %, our mean and 95% interval over 3 seeds at batch 16, and one seed at batch 64.

Arm	Published [11]	Ours (batch 16)	Ours (batch 64)
FP (exact update)	2.0	1.78 [1.75, 1.81]	1.79 (n=1)
SGD on the RPU-baseline device	about 15	14.47 [12.68, 16.26]	24.32 (n=1)
Tiki-Taka (TTv1)	close to 2	2.26 [2.13, 2.39]	2.07 (n=1)
TTv2 (ours, 16 columns per batch)	–	2.59 [2.42, 2.75]	not run

Table 3: Qualitative check of Rasch et al. 2024 (Fig. 5): a 20-state soft-bounds device with an uncorrected reference offset σ_r; test error in % (mean and 95 % t interval, $n = 2$; 10 epochs). FP: 2.69 [0.47, 4.92].

Offset	TTv2	c-TTv2	AGAD
$\sigma_r = 0$	4.12 [2.79, 5.46]	4.29 [3.91, 4.67]	8.47 [7.58, 9.36]
$\sigma_r = 0.5$	24.27 [18.23, 30.30]	13.02 [10.99, 15.05]	7.88 [3.49, 12.26]

4.2 Main comparison on the repaired simulator

Tables 4 and 5 give the gap of every device–algorithm pairing over five seeds, against FP-SGD (the same network, learning rate, initialisation and data order with an exact update) and against digital Adam at its own selected learning rate. Every arm of a seed now shares its initial weights and its data order (checked by hash in every record). The FP-SGD learning rate is reused for every device arm: this is a restricted question (what happens when the FP-SGD rate is reused), not a fair-tuning comparison of the algorithms; Section 4.3 tunes each arm separately.

Against FP-SGD.

- **Plain SGD exceeded the line** in 12 of the 12 cells of the four published devices, at the FP-selected learning rate.
- **All three tasks:** 4 pairings pass on every task: Li-ECRAM c-TTv2, Li-ECRAM AGAD, Protonic-inspired c-TTv2, Protonic-inspired AGAD. No TTv2 pairing does: with the pulse reset, TTv2 fails on CIFAR on every published device.
- **Per task,** 14, 6 and 4 of the 20 device cells pass on MNIST, CIFAR and the LM. W/YSZ/WO$_x$ fails on CIFAR and the LM with every algorithm, and MO-ECRAM fails on the LM.
- **Best cells:** Memistor (optimistic) c-TTv2 on MNIST (0.18 pp), Protonic-inspired AGAD on CIFAR (-1.34 pp) and Protonic-inspired c-TTv2 on the LM (-1.53 %). A negative gap whose interval includes zero is not evidence of superiority; and because these are the best of many cells, they are optimistic.

Against Adam. Digital Adam is the stronger baseline. On the LM FP-SGD is 25.35 % worse in bits per byte than Adam, and **no analog cell comes within the 5 % line of Adam**: the best, Protonic-inspired c-TTv2, is 23.36 % worse (0 of 20 cells pass). On MNIST and CIFAR, where Adam and FP-SGD are close, 14 and 4 cells pass against Adam. No pairing passes all three tasks against Adam (0). The analog results are therefore close to the FP-SGD comparator on these tasks, not to the best digital training in this study.

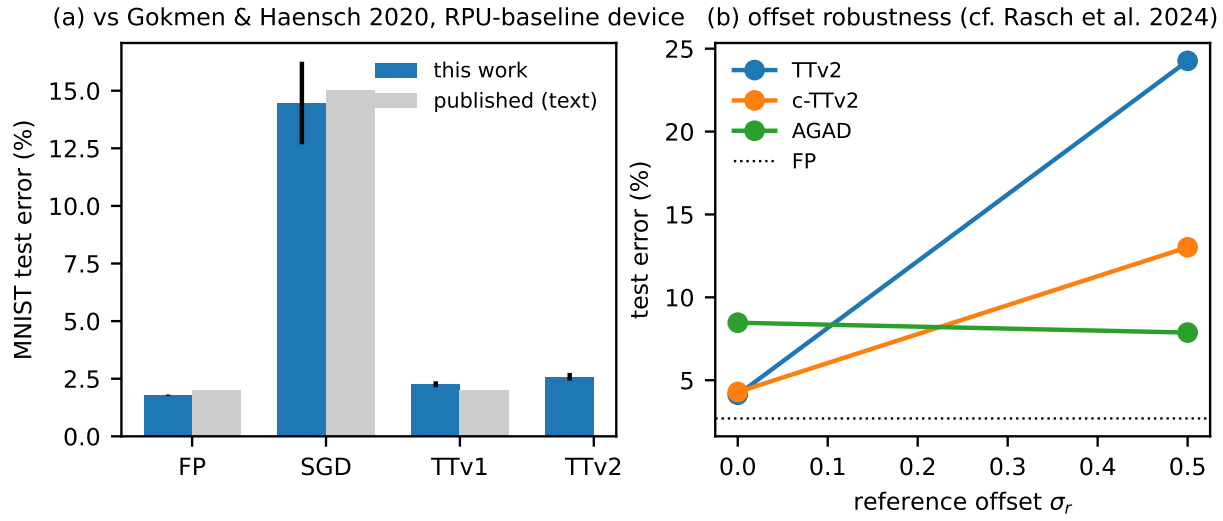


Figure 1: Simulator validation. (a) Test error of our simulator (mean and 95% interval, 3 seeds) against the values stated in the text of Gokmen and Haensch 2020 for their FCN on MNIST with the RPU-baseline device. (b) Robustness to an uncorrected reference offset on a 20-state device (2 seeds), the qualitative trend of Rasch et al. 2024, Fig. 5.

The margins. The lines are practical non-inferiority margins, not equivalence: on MNIST a 2 pp loss from 97.77 % roughly doubles the error rate. UNRESOLVED means insufficient evidence against the margin, never adequate performance. The FP-SGD seed standard deviation is 1.02 pp on CIFAR and 0.078 bits per byte on the LM.

What the update loses. Two properties of the repaired simulator matter for reading these results.

- **Clipping.** The TT family drives its A arrays at ten times the SGD rate, which exceeds the $BL = 31$ pulse budget in the largest layers: the mean lost fraction of the requested A update reaches 57.5 % in the CIFAR output layer and 27.8 % in the LM embedding (plain SGD at most 0.7 % in any layer's mean). This is the hardware's pulse budget, not a simulator error, but it means the effective A rate is capped in those layers.
- **Reset residual.** With at most 62 pulses per weight, the pulse reset leaves a mean residual of 67.00 nominal steps on the read A columns; reset pulses are 3.1 % of all pulses of the pulse-reset runs.

Ideal-device reference. The same algorithms on an ideal device (symmetric, constant step, 1000 levels, no noise, no spread, exact reference) are the rows "Ideal 1000-level" of the tables (deviation R2). On MNIST every algorithm passes on it. On CIFAR and the LM none does: plain SGD loses 6.32 pp and 12.14 % (stochastic pulse updates on a 1000-level grid at the FP-SGD rate), and c-TTv2 and AGAD lose 18.04 and 19.20 pp on CIFAR, far more than on the saturating Li-ECRAM and protonic-inspired devices. With the settings selected here, the TT family relies on the device's own saturation as the decay of its accumulator; the ideal device has none. This is a property of these algorithm settings, not a general requirement that devices saturate: a sufficiently precise symmetric device can implement SGD, as the MNIST row shows.

Table 4: Revised main table (repaired simulator): gap to FP-SGD at the same learning rate, mean [95 % t-interval] over 5 seeds paired by seed (same initialisation and data order); MNIST and CIFAR in accuracy points, LM in % of bits per byte; P/F/U = PASS/FAIL/UNRESOLVED against the absolute lines 2 pp, 2 pp, 5 %.

Device	Alg.	MNIST	CIFAR	LM
Li-ECRAM	SGD	6.41 [3.90, 8.93] F	19.19 [14.94, 23.44] F	51.64 [31.64, 71.63] F
Li-ECRAM	TTv2	0.44 [0.24, 0.64] P	8.65 [6.64, 10.66] F	8.51 [4.72, 12.30] U
Li-ECRAM	c-TTv2	0.62 [0.10, 1.14] P	-0.21 [-2.22, 1.80] P	-1.45 [-4.07, 1.18] P
Li-ECRAM	AGAD	0.57 [0.19, 0.94] P	-0.84 [-2.20, 0.53] P	-1.13 [-3.69, 1.44] P
MO-ECRAM	SGD	11.51 [4.88, 18.14] F	27.24 [20.15, 34.34] F	73.84 [7.33, 140.35] F
MO-ECRAM	TTv2	1.93 [1.82, 2.03] U	7.04 [5.25, 8.83] F	19.31 [15.06, 23.57] F
MO-ECRAM	c-TTv2	1.04 [0.79, 1.28] P	0.33 [-1.60, 2.27] U	11.33 [7.11, 15.55] F
MO-ECRAM	AGAD	0.80 [0.67, 0.93] P	-0.79 [-2.19, 0.62] P	7.98 [6.08, 9.87] F
Protonic-inspired	SGD	4.09 [2.29, 5.88] F	12.66 [8.83, 16.49] F	35.99 [29.87, 42.10] F
Protonic-inspired	TTv2	0.57 [0.07, 1.07] P	6.08 [4.06, 8.10] F	5.34 [1.89, 8.78] U
Protonic-inspired	c-TTv2	0.30 [0.09, 0.51] P	-0.37 [-1.97, 1.23] P	-1.53 [-5.07, 2.01] P
Protonic-inspired	AGAD	0.75 [0.45, 1.04] P	-1.34 [-2.41, -0.27] P	-0.04 [-3.84, 3.76] P
W/WO_x ECRAM	SGD	12.06 [6.69, 17.42] F	33.00 [26.34, 39.67] F	52.03 [43.34, 60.71] F
W/WO_x ECRAM	TTv2	1.47 [1.37, 1.56] P	12.53 [10.59, 14.48] F	22.48 [18.93, 26.04] F
W/WO_x ECRAM	c-TTv2	1.52 [1.31, 1.74] P	10.67 [8.65, 12.69] F	19.02 [14.49, 23.55] F
W/WO_x ECRAM	AGAD	1.07 [0.71, 1.43] P	12.72 [11.44, 14.01] F	21.64 [17.52, 25.76] F
Memistor (optimistic)	SGD	1.60 [0.87, 2.33] U	6.05 [4.35, 7.75] F	25.72 [20.59, 30.86] F
Memistor (optimistic)	TTv2	0.91 [0.64, 1.17] P	1.39 [0.26, 2.52] U	3.70 [0.28, 7.12] U
Memistor (optimistic)	c-TTv2	0.18 [-0.09, 0.46] P	0.44 [-1.37, 2.25] U	3.61 [0.14, 7.07] U
Memistor (optimistic)	AGAD	0.62 [0.29, 0.96] P	0.03 [-1.07, 1.12] P	3.75 [0.44, 7.07] U
Ideal 1000-level	SGD	0.01 [-0.12, 0.13] P	6.32 [2.22, 10.42] F	12.14 [10.28, 14.00] F
Ideal 1000-level	TTv2	0.83 [0.51, 1.16] P	4.72 [0.24, 9.20] U	19.55 [16.07, 23.03] F
Ideal 1000-level	c-TTv2	0.30 [-0.00, 0.60] P	18.04 [10.46, 25.61] F	14.47 [11.99, 16.96] F
Ideal 1000-level	AGAD	0.78 [0.42, 1.14] P	19.20 [13.21, 25.19] F	12.02 [9.00, 15.03] F
Digital	Adam	0.03 [-0.18, 0.23] P	-1.07 [-2.65, 0.52] P	-20.19 [-22.39, -17.99] P

4.3 Width

An earlier lane of this project saw the device gap grow with model width. Here every arm (protonic-inspired and Li-ECRAM, each with TTv2 and c-TTv2) gets its own learning rate at every width by the edge rule on validation, and then five test seeds per width; FP-SGD uses its own selected rate (Table 6). The initial weight scale grows with the width as in the rest of the paper (α set from the initialisation bound), which is one mapping policy, not every fixed physical mapping.

The test. The endpoint contrast D (the mean gap at the widest minus the narrowest width) is tested for equivalence within the gap lines (TOST at 5 %). The original paper's "FLAT" label is withdrawn: it did not test equivalence and covered large non-monotonic changes.

CIFAR ($c = 16$, 32, 64). 1 arm is equivalent within ±2 pp (Li-ECRAM c-TTv2, $D = -0.34$ pp, 90 % interval [-1.34, 0.66]); for 1 arm there is no evidence of growth beyond the margin (protonic-inspired TTv2); 2 arms are inconclusive (Li-ECRAM TTv2, $D = 1.91$ pp; protonic-inspired c-TTv2, $D = 1.76$ pp). Five seeds are not enough to settle a 2 pp margin on this subset.

The LM ($d = 64$, 128, 256). All 4 arms have a gap that shrinks with width (for example Li-ECRAM c-TTv2 from 1.21 % to -12.90 %). This is not a favourable scaling law: FP-SGD itself gets worse at the largest width under the fixed budget (2.962 bits per byte at $d = 128$, 3.117 at

Table 5: Revised main table (repaired simulator): gap to digital Adam (its own selected learning rate), mean [95 % t-interval] over 5 seeds paired by seed (same initialisation and data order); MNIST and CIFAR in accuracy points, LM in % of bits per byte; P/F/U = PASS/FAIL/UNRESOLVED against the absolute lines 2 pp, 2 pp, 5 %.

Device	Alg.	MNIST	CIFAR	LM
Li-ECRAM	SGD	6.39 [3.79, 8.98] F	20.25 [14.51, 26.00] F	90.33 [60.59, 120.07] F
Li-ECRAM	TTv2	0.42 [0.21, 0.63] P	9.72 [8.82, 10.62] F	35.95 [34.87, 37.02] F
Li-ECRAM	c-TTv2	0.60 [0.26, 0.93] P	0.86 [0.17, 1.55] P	23.49 [22.61, 24.36] F
Li-ECRAM	AGAD	0.54 [0.26, 0.82] P	0.23 [-0.38, 0.84] P	23.89 [22.95, 24.82] F
MO-ECRAM	SGD	11.48 [4.73, 18.23] F	28.31 [20.59, 36.03] F	117.64 [35.42, 199.87] F
MO-ECRAM	TTv2	1.90 [1.77, 2.04] U	8.11 [7.85, 8.38] F	49.48 [47.97, 50.98] F
MO-ECRAM	c-TTv2	1.01 [0.96, 1.06] P	1.40 [0.28, 2.53] U	39.47 [37.39, 41.55] F
MO-ECRAM	AGAD	0.78 [0.60, 0.96] P	0.28 [-0.30, 0.86] P	35.33 [31.48, 39.19] F
Protonic-inspired	SGD	4.06 [2.18, 5.94] F	13.73 [10.41, 17.05] F	70.37 [65.57, 75.16] F
Protonic-inspired	TTv2	0.54 [0.23, 0.86] P	7.15 [5.27, 9.04] F	31.98 [30.89, 33.06] F
Protonic-inspired	c-TTv2	0.27 [0.16, 0.38] P	0.70 [-1.68, 3.07] U	23.36 [22.15, 24.58] F
Protonic-inspired	AGAD	0.72 [0.58, 0.86] P	-0.27 [-1.30, 0.75] P	25.23 [23.43, 27.03] F
W/WO$_x$ ECRAM	SGD	12.03 [6.56, 17.50] F	34.07 [28.80, 39.34] F	90.44 [82.88, 97.99] F
W/WO$_x$ ECRAM	TTv2	1.44 [1.23, 1.66] P	13.60 [11.76, 15.44] F	53.46 [52.68, 54.24] F
W/WO$_x$ ECRAM	c-TTv2	1.50 [1.39, 1.60] P	11.74 [10.96, 12.52] F	49.10 [47.30, 50.90] F
W/WO$_x$ ECRAM	AGAD	1.04 [0.66, 1.42] P	13.79 [12.70, 14.88] F	52.40 [51.04, 53.75] F
Memistor (optimistic)	SGD	1.58 [0.75, 2.41] U	7.12 [4.95, 9.30] F	57.52 [53.05, 61.99] F
Memistor (optimistic)	TTv2	0.88 [0.57, 1.19] P	2.46 [0.65, 4.28] U	29.93 [28.82, 31.03] F
Memistor (optimistic)	c-TTv2	0.16 [0.01, 0.30] P	1.51 [-0.47, 3.49] U	29.80 [28.39, 31.22] F
Memistor (optimistic)	AGAD	0.60 [0.35, 0.84] P	1.09 [-0.24, 2.43] U	29.99 [28.42, 31.56] F
Ideal 1000-level	SGD	-0.02 [-0.22, 0.18] P	7.39 [3.31, 11.46] F	40.53 [38.35, 42.71] F
Ideal 1000-level	TTv2	0.81 [0.54, 1.07] P	5.79 [0.66, 10.91] U	49.79 [48.21, 51.37] F
Ideal 1000-level	c-TTv2	0.27 [0.10, 0.44] P	19.10 [10.33, 27.87] F	43.45 [41.48, 45.41] F
Ideal 1000-level	AGAD	0.75 [0.47, 1.03] P	20.27 [15.32, 25.22] F	40.36 [38.70, 42.01] F

$d = 256$), so a gap that turns negative partly measures a weaker baseline. Converged or quality-matched baselines would be needed to speak of scaling.

What can be said. Across a factor of four in width, after per-arm learning-rate selection, our pre-registered test detected no growth of the device gap on either task; on CIFAR it established equivalence for one arm only, and on the LM the apparent shrinkage reflects the FP-SGD baseline at a fixed budget. Width is not resolved by this study.

4.4 Sensitivity against absolute lines

Around the protonic-inspired base we move one device property at a time (levels, step asymmetry, saturation γ, write noise, reference error, retention) at the base sizes (CIFAR $c = 32$, LM $d = 128$), three seeds paired with FP-SGD of the same seed, at FP-SGD's learning rate. Every grid point is labelled against the *absolute* line (2 pp, 5 %), never against the base device's own gap (Table 7). The asymmetry sweep is run twice: as before, where the symmetry point $u^* = a/(2\gamma)$ moves toward the upper bound and the positive weight range shrinks ($a = 0.4$ at $\gamma = 0.2$ puts u^* on the bound); and with each device's range re-centred on its symmetry point, so that only the up/down dynamics change.

The pre-registered sheet (TTv2) establishes no threshold. Its base point is itself UNRESOLVED on both tasks (6.35 pp on CIFAR, 5.15 % on the LM), so by the pre-registered rule every

Table 6: Revised width study: gap per width (5 seeds, each arm at its own selected learning rate), the endpoint contrast D (widest minus narrowest) with its 90 % Welch interval, and the pre-registered equivalence verdict (margins 2 pp CIFAR, 5 % LM).

Task	Device	Alg.	narrow	mid	wide	D [90 %]	verd
CIFAR	Li-ECRAM	c-TTv2	-0.36 [-1.06, 0.33] P	0.66 [-1.24, 2.56] U	-0.71 [-1.96, 0.55] P	-0.34 [-1.34, 0.66]	EQ
CIFAR	Li-ECRAM	TTv2	3.29 [1.13, 5.44] U	4.12 [2.54, 5.70] F	5.20 [2.64, 7.75] F	1.91 [-0.37, 4.19]	INC
CIFAR	Protonic-inspired	c-TTv2	-2.57 [-4.80, -0.34] P	-1.55 [-3.14, 0.04] P	-0.81 [-1.46, -0.16] P	1.76 [-0.02, 3.55]	INC
CIFAR	Protonic-inspired	TTv2	1.38 [-0.04, 2.80] U	2.71 [1.28, 4.14] U	0.43 [-1.39, 2.25] U	-0.95 [-2.53, 0.62]	no g
LM	Li-ECRAM	c-TTv2	1.21 [0.10, 2.33] P	-4.69 [-6.31, -3.08] P	-12.90 [-14.38, -11.43] P	-14.12 [-15.38, -12.86]	SHI
LM	Li-ECRAM	TTv2	9.85 [8.56, 11.13] F	13.29 [-1.63, 28.20] U	-3.07 [-5.08, -1.07] P	-12.92 [-14.59, -11.25]	SHI
LM	Protonic-inspired	c-TTv2	-5.79 [-7.12, -4.46] P	-6.36 [-14.23, 1.52] P	-12.69 [-13.83, -11.54] P	-6.90 [-8.10, -5.70]	SHI
LM	Protonic-inspired	TTv2	7.95 [1.84, 14.05] U	0.39 [-1.47, 2.25] P	-6.49 [-8.18, -4.80] P	-14.44 [-19.30, -9.57]	SHI

axis is "not established". It still shows the confound the review pointed out: at $a = 0.4$ the gap is 42.92 pp on CIFAR when the symmetry point moves onto the bound, but 6.20 pp when it is held at mid-range. The earlier "asymmetry limit" was mostly lost weight range.

The chopped-TTv2 sheet (added after the main table, deviation R3). On CIFAR the base passes (-0.85 pp, PASS), and the sheet establishes: step asymmetry up to 0.2 with the symmetry point moving (at 0.4 the gap jumps to 42.39 pp, when u^* reaches the bound), and reference error up to 0.05 of the half range. With the symmetry point held at mid-range only the base value is established (0.05), but no point fails: up to $a = 0.4$ the mean gap stays at -0.53 pp and the intervals merely include the line. Levels, saturation, write noise and finite retention are not established: neighbouring grid values are UNRESOLVED with three seeds, while the clear failures are no saturation ($\gamma = 0$: 21.14 pp), strong saturation ($\gamma = 1$: 8.01 pp), reference error 0.2 (9.31 pp) and retention of 10^3 updates or less. On the LM the base is UNRESOLVED with three seeds (-1.84 %; it passed with five seeds in the main table), so no LM threshold is established.

How to read the sheet. These are one-at-a-time ranges around one base device, for one algorithm setting, at FP-SGD's learning rate, with three seeds; they are exploratory, not fabrication tolerances. Combined deviations, other algorithm settings and independent device populations are not covered. A near-zero saturation fails here because, with these settings, the accumulator's decay comes from the device (Section 4.2); it is not a general requirement for training.

5 A conditional energy projection for the weight-matrix operations

This section is an accounting scenario, not an energy measurement of a training system. It asks how much energy the weight-matrix operations of a training step would take if the analog reads ran at the efficiency of a published analog-AI *inference* chip and the updates cost the published or projected pulse energies, and it compares that with an H100.

Assumptions, stated first.

1. **Different read assumptions for accuracy and energy.** The accuracies of Section 4.2 are simulated with ideal fp32 reads; the energy prices finite-precision analog reads. We have not shown that one operating point gives both the reported accuracy and the assumed read efficiency.

Table 7: Revised sensitivity sheet (protonic-inspired base; TTv2 = the pre-registered S-ALGO, c-TTv2 added after the main table was seen, deviation R3; 3 seeds paired with FP-SGD): mean gap per grid value with its label against the ABSOLUTE line (P/F/U), and the weakest value that passes with every value toward the best end also passing (– = not established).

Alg., task	Axis	mean gap per value	threshold
c-TTv2, CIFAR	levels	5000.0: 2.49U; 2000.0: -2.43P; 1000: -0.85P; 500.0: -1.57P; 200.0: 1.38U; 100.0: 1.68U	–
c-TTv2, CIFAR	asym. a (SP moves)	0.0: -1.43P; 0.05: -0.85P; 0.1: -1.64P; 0.2: -1.16P; 0.4: 42.39F	0.2
c-TTv2, CIFAR	asym. a (SP fixed)	0.05: -0.85P; 0.1: -0.82U; 0.2: -1.38U; 0.4: -0.53U	0.05
c-TTv2, CIFAR	nonlin. γ	0.0: 21.14F; 0.2: -0.85P; 0.5: 1.88U; 1.0: 8.01F; 2.0: 14.77F	–
c-TTv2, CIFAR	noise c_{2c}	0.0: -0.64U; 0.3: -0.85P; 1.0: -1.34U; 2.0: 0.61U; 4.0: 5.37U	–
c-TTv2, CIFAR	ref. err. σ_r	0.0: -1.20P; 0.02: -0.85P; 0.05: -1.29P; 0.1: 2.89U; 0.2: 9.31F; 0.5: 34.63F	0.05
c-TTv2, CIFAR	retention τ	inf: -0.85P; 100000.0: -1.17U; 10000.0: 3.08U; 1000.0: 33.02F; 100.0: 44.03F	inf
c-TTv2, LM	levels	5000.0: 2.01U; 2000.0: -2.63U; 1000: -1.84U; 500.0: -0.45U; 200.0: 1.58U; 100.0: 6.54U	–
c-TTv2, LM	asym. a (SP moves)	0.0: -1.68U; 0.05: -1.84U; 0.1: -1.54U; 0.2: -1.85U; 0.4: 37.71U	–
c-TTv2, LM	asym. a (SP fixed)	0.05: -1.84U; 0.1: -1.69U; 0.2: -1.70U; 0.4: -1.68U	–
c-TTv2, LM	nonlin. γ	0.0: 22.71F; 0.2: -1.84U; 0.5: -0.39U; 1.0: 4.46U; 2.0: 27.27U	–
c-TTv2, LM	noise c_{2c}	0.0: -1.51U; 0.3: -1.84U; 1.0: -0.21U; 2.0: 4.91U; 4.0: 19.04F	–
c-TTv2, LM	ref. err. σ_r	0.0: -2.42U; 0.02: -1.84U; 0.05: 1.45U; 0.1: 8.23U; 0.2: 17.53F; 0.5: 30.83F	–
c-TTv2, LM	retention τ	inf: -1.84U; 100000.0: -1.75U; 10000.0: -3.47U; 1000.0: 28.50F; 100.0: 64.34F	–
TTv2, CIFAR	levels	5000.0: 0.78U; 2000.0: 1.67U; 1000: 6.35U; 500.0: 4.43U; 200.0: 3.13U; 100.0: 3.12U	–
TTv2, CIFAR	asym. a (SP moves)	0.0: 5.92U; 0.05: 6.35U; 0.1: 5.95F; 0.2: 6.39F; 0.4: 42.92F	–
TTv2, CIFAR	asym. a (SP fixed)	0.05: 6.35U; 0.1: 6.12U; 0.2: 4.60U; 0.4: 6.20U	–
TTv2, CIFAR	nonlin. γ	0.0: 27.43F; 0.2: 6.35U; 0.5: 9.00F; 1.0: 8.22F; 2.0: 12.20F	–
TTv2, CIFAR	noise c_{2c}	0.0: 5.79U; 0.3: 6.35U; 1.0: 6.19U; 2.0: 7.18U; 4.0: 9.40F	–
TTv2, CIFAR	ref. err. σ_r	0.0: 5.08U; 0.02: 6.35U; 0.05: 5.35U; 0.1: 9.94F; 0.2: 18.74F; 0.5: 30.32F	–
TTv2, CIFAR	retention τ	inf: 6.35U; 100000.0: 4.49U; 10000.0: 5.18U; 1000.0: 40.83F; 100.0: 47.25F	–
TTv2, LM	levels	5000.0: 7.33U; 2000.0: 4.67U; 1000: 5.15U; 500.0: 5.87U; 200.0: 7.38U; 100.0: 9.64U	–
TTv2, LM	asym. a (SP moves)	0.0: 5.26U; 0.05: 5.15U; 0.1: 5.21U; 0.2: 5.00U; 0.4: 10.38U	–
TTv2, LM	asym. a (SP fixed)	0.05: 5.15U; 0.1: 5.28U; 0.2: 5.29U; 0.4: 5.75U	–
TTv2, LM	nonlin. γ	0.0: 32.24F; 0.2: 5.15U; 0.5: 11.13U; 1.0: 18.03F; 2.0: 25.84F	–
TTv2, LM	noise c_{2c}	0.0: 5.14U; 0.3: 5.15U; 1.0: 5.56U; 2.0: 7.85U; 4.0: 15.03U	–
TTv2, LM	ref. err. σ_r	0.0: 4.59U; 0.02: 5.15U; 0.05: 7.27U; 0.1: 11.43U; 0.2: 19.66F; 0.5: 31.81F	–
TTv2, LM	retention τ	inf: 5.15U; 100000.0: 5.09U; 10000.0: 3.74U; 1000.0: 30.34F; 100.0: 71.47F	–

2. **The read efficiency is borrowed from a phase-change inference chip** [36]: up to 12.4 TOPS/W sustained on one chip, and 6.94 TOPS/W for the authors' five-chip system once communication, unused tiles and digital work are counted (buses and regulators excluded). We report both. Neither is an ECRAM training array, which also needs backward reads, repeated writes, references and Tiki-Taka state.

3. **The boundary is the weight matrices.** Per weight and per training row: the forward and backward reads (two MACs) and the update (device pulses, pulse lines and pulse generation, and the TT family's column reads and digital buffer). Attention products, nonlinearities, normalisation, activation storage, data movement, control, reference maintenance and static power are not modelled on either side, and the digital exclusions do not cancel the analog ones.

4. **The GPU side** is H100 board power over its dense BF16 peak [43] at the utilisation of a very large training run, 38–43 % [44]: 10.48 pJ per weight per row (7.05–11.17 pJ over that range; 5.51–14.15 pJ over the 30–55 % range of our original plan).

Projection. With the repaired pulse counts (resets counted as applied, the pulse reset's extra reads included), the GPU-to-analog ratio per weight per row is 31.5–32.4× at the 12.4 TOPS/W chip figure and 17.9–18.1× at the 6.94 TOPS/W system figure, for every published device and

Table 8: Conditional energy projection at equal quality: the GPU-to-analog energy ratio per weight per row (12.4 TOPS/W chip figure / 6.94 TOPS/W system figure of the same inference chip), printed only where the cell PASSES against the baseline; n.r. = the quality is not reached (FAIL or UNRESOLVED).

		MNIST		CIFAR		LM	
Device	Alg.	FP-SGD	Adam	FP-SGD	Adam	FP-SGD	Adam
Li-ECRAM	SGD	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
Li-ECRAM	TTv2	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
Li-ECRAM	c-TTv2	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.
Li-ECRAM	AGAD	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.
MO-ECRAM	SGD	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
MO-ECRAM	TTv2	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
MO-ECRAM	c-TTv2	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
MO-ECRAM	AGAD	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.	n.r.
Protonic-inspired	SGD	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
Protonic-inspired	TTv2	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
Protonic-inspired	c-TTv2	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.	32 / 18	n.r.
Protonic-inspired	AGAD	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.
W/WO_x ECRAM	SGD	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
W/WO_x ECRAM	TTv2	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
W/WO_x ECRAM	c-TTv2	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.
W/WO_x ECRAM	AGAD	32 / 18	32 / 18	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.	n.r.

algorithm. The reads are at least 97.0 % of the analog total: the ratio is set almost entirely by the two borrowed efficiencies, and changes in the simulated pulse counts barely move it.

Energy to equal quality. A low energy per operation is worth nothing if the target quality is not reached. We therefore report the ratio only for cells that PASS against the stated baseline (Table 8):

- against FP-SGD: 11, 5 and 4 of the 16 published-device cells per task (MNIST, CIFAR, LM);
- against Adam: 11, 4 and 0 cells. **On the LM no analog cell reaches Adam's quality, so no energy-to-equal-quality ratio exists against the stronger digital baseline.**

The comparison is at a fixed training budget; reaching a quality at a different number of steps is not modelled.

What 100× would need. At the central GPU figure, a 100× ratio needs reads at about 38.6–42.2 TOPS/W including their periphery, several times the chip figure above.

The memistor. Widrow's macroscopic memistor moves tens of microjoules of plating charge per level; its ratio is at most 8.0×10^{-4} (far worse than the GPU), as expected for wet, centimetre-scale cells.

6 Discussion

What the repaired simulations say, within their limits.

- **Against FP-SGD, two device specifications reach the line on all three tasks** with a chopped Tiki-Taka algorithm: the AIHWKIT Li-ECRAM fit and the protonic-inspired scenario, each with c-TTv2 or AGAD (4 pairings).

- **Against Adam, none does.** On the language model the best analog cell is 23.36 % worse in bits per byte; the analog results inherit FP-SGD's optimiser gap (25.35 % on this model). Closing it would need analog-compatible adaptive updates, which this study does not test.
- **Plain SGD at the FP-SGD learning rate** exceeded the margin on every published device and task we ran (12 of 12 cells). This is a statement about that protocol, not about SGD after fair tuning.
- **The algorithm settings use the device.** On an ideal symmetric 1000-level device the selected TT settings lose far more than on the saturating devices, so in this configuration the accumulator's decay comes from the device's saturation.
- **Width** is not resolved: no growth was detected over a factor of four after per-arm tuning, equivalence was established for one CIFAR arm, and the LM's shrinking gap reflects a weaker FP-SGD baseline at the largest width.
- **Energy** is a conditional projection set almost entirely by borrowed read efficiencies, and it is reported only where the quality is reached; against Adam on the LM it is never reached.

Widrow's memistor. Taken at its inventor's description (thousands of near-linear levels), an optimistic historical-device scenario attained useful accuracy in this simulator; the pessimistic twin does not. Because its noise, asymmetry, drift and variability are largely unknown, this does not settle the accuracy of the real 1960 device. Its energy per level, tens of microjoules, is many orders of magnitude worse than today's devices.

6.1 Limitations

- **Simulation only.** Every device is a parametric model; the protonic entry is a scenario with estimated noise, asymmetry and saturation, and its finite retention is replaced by no drift. A 2026 measurement on BEOL-compatible protonic ECRAM [8] reports 3 % cycle-to-cycle and 21 % device-to-device variability; we did not refit the catalog to it, and we could not check those values against the full text. Estimated parameters are single points, not propagated ranges.
- **Ideal reads.** Read noise, IR drop, ADC/DAC quantisation and output bounds are not modelled, while the energy projection prices finite-precision reads.
- **The update surrogate.** Pulses of one batch are aggregated and solved as uniformly interleaved; discrete pulses do not commute, per-cell Poisson draws ignore row/column correlations, and the pulse budget clips the TT family's A updates by up to 57.5 % in some layers. We did not compare against a sequential pulse-by-pulse simulation on training cells.
- **The reset.** The pulse reset uses a read and at most 62 pulses per weight; it leaves a residual (mean 67.00 nominal steps) and its latency and endurance cost are not modelled.
- **Algorithms.** TTv1, TTv2, c-TTv2 and AGAD were implemented from the papers' text; our TTv2 is a local variant (multi-pulse transfer, buffer remainder). The settings were selected once, on MNIST, with a mid device.
- **Small models and short budgets.** 10^5 to 10^6 weights, a 10,000-image CIFAR subset, a two-layer byte LM, a factor of four in width, fixed training budgets.

- **Statistics.** Five seeds (three in the sensitivity sheet and the diagnostic), no multiplicity correction, and best cells chosen among many; several cells remain UNRESOLVED.
- **Plans.** The plans were committed to our repository before the runs; they are not registered in an external registry.

7 A proposed roadmap for groups with device and fabrication resources

The simulations suggest what to measure first. None of the criteria below is an established device qualification: each is conditional on this simulator (ideal reads, the pulse surrogate, small models) and on the chopped Tiki-Taka setting that passed in Section 4.2.

Stage 1: single-device characterisation (tens of devices, no array).

- **Measurement.** At least 1000 up and 1000 down pulses at the intended width and voltage, repeated at least three times on at least 32 devices, with the read current measured (not inferred) and incomplete pulses rejected. Fit: step against state (saturation $\gamma_{\pm}$), up/down asymmetry, cycle-to-cycle noise (separated from read noise), device-to-device spreads, the symmetry point and the signed weight range around it, and drift.
- **What the simulations support** (c-TTv2 sheet, CIFAR $c = 32$, absolute 2 pp line, three seeds, Table 7): a step asymmetry up to 0.2 and a reference error up to 0.05 of the half range, one axis at a time around the protonic-inspired base. Thresholds for levels, saturation, write noise and retention are not established by this grid; what it shows is where training clearly fails (no saturation or $\gamma \geq 1$, reference error 0.2, retention of 10^3 updates or less). A device group should therefore measure all of these and simulate its own fitted device, rather than read pass lines off this sheet. Combined deviations are not covered.
- **Endurance and pulse budget.** Report per-array and per-layer pulse distributions and the hottest cells, not only averages; the TT family's A arrays and the resets dominate the write load, and the pulse budget per update clips the largest layers (Section 4.2).

Stage 2: the symmetry point and the reset as physical processes.

- **Measurement.** The pulse count, latency and energy to bring a device to its symmetry point or to its read zero; the residual error, its spread and its drift over hours and 10^6 cycles; the signed range left on each side.
- **Why.** With a realistic pulse budget the reset is incomplete (on the protonic-inspired device, 62 alternating pulses leave 97.55 % of a displacement), so the reset is a device specification, not a free operation.

Stage 3: small arrays with hardware in the loop.

- **Hardware.** Two 64×64 arrays per layer (A and C); forward and backward passes on the host from the read weights; updates on chip as stochastic pulse coincidences; resets or chopping as the algorithm requires.

- **Prediction first.** Before training, fit the Stage 1 model on several independent chips, run this simulator with the fit, and state a *prediction interval* that includes device-population variation, fit uncertainty, training randomness and measurement noise (not a confidence interval of the simulated mean, which shrinks with more seeds). The hardware should land inside it; independently, within 2 pp of FP-SGD shows the device works.

Stage 4: full arrays and in-memory reads. Move the forward and backward reads on chip and measure the system energy per weight per row, with the read precision that gives the accuracy, against the conditional projection of Section 5; convert retention requirements into time with the full step duration.

The 1960 memistor. Appendix A gives a proposed, unbuilt bench replication protocol with hobby parts and safety notes. Before its fits are used as metrology it must measure the actual read current, keep per-pulse charge, separate read from write noise and reject incomplete pulses.

8 Conclusion

In this simulator, with ideal reads and every update made of device pulses, two electrochemical specifications (the AIHWKIT Li-ECRAM fit and a protonic-inspired scenario) train three small networks to within the pre-set margins of SGD with exact updates when a chopped Tiki-Taka algorithm moves the gradient; plain SGD at the same learning rate does not on any published device. Against a tuned digital Adam none of them does, and on the language model the best is 23.36 % worse in bits per byte. No growth of the gap with width was detected over a factor of four, without establishing equivalence. The energy advantage is a conditional projection (17.9–32.4× per weight-row at borrowed inference-chip read efficiencies), reached only where the quality is. After an independent review we repaired the simulator and report how much each repair moved the original results. The remaining questions are experimental: the reset, the reference and the read path in real arrays.

9 Code and data availability

Nothing has been deposited publicly yet. On deposit, one archive will hold everything needed to reproduce this paper, with versions, source hashes, dataset digests and split offsets, run manifests and licences:

- the plans (`PLAN-PAPER.md`, `PLAN-REVISION.md`), their deviations (`DEVIATIONS-PAPER.md`) and the response to the independent review (`RESPONSE-TO-REVIEW.md`);
- the original simulator and the repaired one (`sim/*_rev.py`), with their checks;
- the device catalog with per-field provenance;
- every run record (one JSON file per training run, with its configuration, metric, pulse counts and hardware);
- the scripts that derive every number, table and figure of this paper from those records (`analyze.py`, `make_figures.py`, `energy/energy_system.py`; for the revision `revision/analyze_rev.py`, `revision/analyze_d1.py`, `revision/compare_curves.py`, `energy/energy_rev.py`);

- the citation check (every reference verified against Crossref, the arXiv API or the live URL; `records/CITE-CHECK.json`);
- the bench protocol.

The archive DOI will be added on deposit (Zenodo). Data: MNIST, CIFAR-10 and enwik8 are public and pinned by digest. All text data used for training is human-written (Wikipedia, 2006).

Author contributions and use of AI

Questeria conceived and directed the study. Claude (Anthropic), an AI system, wrote the simulator and its checks, designed and pre-registered the experiments under Questeria's direction, ran them on rented cloud GPUs, analysed the records, verified the references, and drafted the text.

Under the policies of arXiv [45] and of most journals, an AI system cannot be an author or take responsibility for a paper. For any formal submission the arXiv-compliant variant of this paper lists Questeria as the sole author and states Claude's role in this section. All numbers were produced by scripts from the released records.

Acknowledgments

We thank the authors of the open-access papers and of the open-source AIHWKIT whose published device fits and algorithm descriptions made this study possible. No external funding was received. Compute was rented by the author.

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A Bench replication of the 1960 memistor

This appendix is a protocol for others to run. We built nothing and bought nothing. It is meant to measure, with hobby parts, the properties that Widrow's reports leave open (Section 2): levels, up/down symmetry, linearity, write noise, drift and energy per step. The measured cell can then be placed on the same map as the modern devices. The full protocol, an Arduino sketch, a parts list with estimated prices, and an analysis script that turns the log into a device specification for our simulator are in the repository (`BENCH.md`, `bench/`).

Pass criteria. The cell must show at least 32 near-linear, symmetric levels on one lead: over at least 32 consecutive equal-charge pulses in each direction,

1. the mean up step and the mean down step agree within 10%;
2. the step varies by less than $\pm 30\%$ across the range ($\gamma \leq 0.3$);

3. the pulse-to-pulse scatter is below half a step ($c_{2c} \leq 0.5$).

A four-input ADALINE trained by LMS on four such leads should then cut its mean squared error at least tenfold.

Build.

- Electrolyte: 0.5 M copper(II) sulphate in distilled water. Sulphuric acid and brighteners are deliberately left out for safety, so expect some hysteresis.
- Electrodes: 2 mm HB graphite leads with wrapped-wire contacts, the lower contact insulated with nail polish, a wetted length of about 20 mm, and a bare copper counter electrode.
- Electronics: an Arduino Nano, an INA219 current/voltage sensor, and a CD4052 multiplexer for four-wire reads.

Protocol.

1. Read-noise baseline.
2. Plating range in 1 mC pulses.
3. 64 pulses down and 64 up from mid-range, repeated, to measure the step against conductance, the asymmetry and the scatter.
4. A two-hour (ideally overnight) drift run, covered and then stirred, to separate oxygen-driven corrosion.
5. The integral of cell voltage × current per pulse, which gives the energy per step.
6. 20 full cycles to measure endurance.
7. The LMS ADALINE.

Safety.

- Copper sulphate is harmful if swallowed, irritates eyes and skin, and is very toxic to aquatic life. Wear splash goggles and nitrile gloves, and work on a tray away from food, children and pets.
- Use low voltage only (USB). Keep electronics out of splash range, keep aluminium away from the solution, and reduce the current if bubbles form.
- Never pour waste down the drain. Take it to household hazardous-waste collection.
- For eye contact, rinse for 15 minutes and seek medical advice.

What the bench cannot show. A pencil-lead memistor is macroscopic. Its energy per step is set by the copper moved, about 15 μJ per level by Widrow's figures and 986 μJ for our pencil-lead estimate. That is many orders of magnitude above an H100's energy per weight update (Section 5). The bench can confirm or refute the linearity and symmetry the memistor promised; it cannot make training cheaper. The cheap direction, if any, is the nanoscale descendants.

B Hyperparameter selection

Learning rates and algorithm settings were selected on validation splits only, with seed 0.

- **MNIST learning rate.** The FP grid was $\{3 \times 10^{-4}, 10^{-3}, 3 \times 10^{-3}, 10^{-2}\}$, extended by the edge rule. The choice is 0.003.
- **TT-family settings.** They were chosen on MNIST validation with a mid-quality device (128 levels, asymmetry 0.1, γ 0.3, c_{2c} 0.5, σ_r 0.02):
  - TTv2: $\lambda \in \{0.1, 0.3, 1, 3\}$ and a period of 16 or 64 batches, with or without a matched A learning rate;
  - c-TTv2: $\lambda \in \{0.1, 0.3\}$, $\rho \in \{0.05, 0.2\}$, with or without reset;
  - AGAD: $\lambda \in \{0.1, 0.3\}$, $\rho \in \{0.05, 0.2\}$, $\beta \in \{0.3, 1\}$.
- **Derived choices.** The better chopped algorithm (c-TTv2) is used in the scale study, and the best of the three (TTv2) in the specification sheet.
- **CIFAR and LM learning rates** were chosen per width (Section 4.3).

Table 9: Settings chosen on MNIST validation with the mid device (Appendix B); validation accuracy in %.

Algorithm	Chosen setting	Val. acc.
TTv2	λ 0.1, A lr $\times$10, period 16	97.86
c-TTv2	λ 0.1, A lr $\times$10, period 16, ρ 0.2, reset yes	97.82
AGAD	λ 0.1, A lr $\times$10, period 16, ρ 0.05, β 0.3, reset no	97.18

C Simulator checks

Each check runs twice. On the real code it must pass. Once for every planted fault it must fail, which shows that the check catches that fault. A crash under a fault also counts as caught. Both suites ran on the desk before the plan was committed, and again at the start of every cloud session; any failure would have stopped the session.

D Earlier development results

This study began as an exploratory screen with the same simulator (SGD and TTv2 only, 1–3 seeds). The screen is summarised here because some of its observations motivated the pre-registered experiments:

- a CIFAR gap "just over 2 pp";
- a gap that "grows with width";
- a "pencil lead built today" that fails every task.

The earlier runs differ from this paper's in three ways:

Table 10: Simulator checks and the planted faults each one catches (records/TESTS-PAPER.json, records/TESTS-laneME-checks-on-paper-sim.json).

Check	Result	Planted faults caught
`c_asym_drift`	pass	asymmetry ignored
`c_c2c_noise`	pass	write noise $\sim$ n not sqrt(n)
`c_constant_step_reference`	pass	constant-step reference at a bound (the D1 bug)
`c_drift`	pass	drift relaxes to 0 not bare
`c_fp_equivalence`	pass	apply_exact sign flipped
`c_level_step`	pass	step size halved
`c_pulse_mean`	pass	pulse slots BL dropped; pulse up/down swapped
`c_symmetry_point`	pass	symmetry point sign
`c_ttv2_learns`	pass	TT transfer sign flipped
`c_family_learns`	pass	A-update inputs not chopped
`c_gamma_d2d_sp`	pass	gamma spread shared by the whole tile
`c_identity_sgd_ttv2`	pass	down-branch saturation uses gamma_up
`c_offset_rejection`	pass	AGAD reference never set; chopper demodulation missing; chopper never flips
`c_ttv1_direction`	pass	TTv1 transfer sign flipped

- MNIST ran on a different GPU;
- the LM's selection split overlapped its training data (corrected here, Section 3.5);
- CIFAR and the LM had one or two seeds.

With five seeds the earlier point estimates are mostly confirmed (Table 11), but the earlier pass/fail readings were not meaningful at that sample size. The CIFAR baseline's seed-to-seed spread is comparable to the gap line itself.

The pessimistic memistor and the pencil-lead estimate were run only in the earlier screen. Both fail every task with SGD and with TTv2. Their specifications are estimates; the bench protocol of Appendix A would replace the pencil-lead estimate by measurements.

Table 11: Earlier development results (lane ME: same simulator, 1–3 seeds, MNIST on a different GPU, the LM selected on an overlapping split) beside this paper's pre-registered 5-seed values. Gaps in pp (MNIST, CIFAR) and % (LM). The pessimistic memistor and the pencil lead appear only in the earlier runs.

		MNIST		CIFAR		LM	
Device	Alg.	earlier	this paper	earlier	this paper	earlier	this paper
Li-ECRAM (Tang 2018)	SGD	5.24 (n=3)	4.85 (n=5)	21.78 (n=1)	20.81 (n=5)	39.75 (n=1)	45.58 (n=5)
Li-ECRAM (Tang 2018)	TTv2	1.17 (n=3)	1.32 (n=5)	2.15 (n=2)	2.95 (n=5)	4.08 (n=2)	3.52 (n=5)
Protonic (Onen 2022)	SGD	3.67 (n=3)	3.07 (n=5)	19.54 (n=1)	15.77 (n=5)	37.62 (n=1)	40.82 (n=5)
Protonic (Onen 2022)	TTv2	0.77 (n=3)	1.04 (n=5)	2.13 (n=2)	2.13 (n=5)	4.21 (n=2)	3.64 (n=5)
MO-ECRAM (Kim 2019)	SGD	7.20 (n=3)	6.96 (n=5)	26.19 (n=1)	25.29 (n=5)	76.49 (n=1)	50.84 (n=5)
MO-ECRAM (Kim 2019)	TTv2	1.84 (n=3)	1.80 (n=5)	8.04 (n=1)	5.45 (n=5)	17.19 (n=1)	16.51 (n=5)
W/YSZ/WO_x (Chen 2023)	SGD	8.19 (n=3)	8.25 (n=5)	37.88 (n=1)	36.82 (n=5)	54.79 (n=1)	50.67 (n=5)
W/YSZ/WO_x (Chen 2023)	TTv2	1.49 (n=3)	1.48 (n=5)	10.45 (n=1)	10.59 (n=5)	20.77 (n=1)	21.17 (n=5)
Memistor (Widrow 1960, as claimed)	SGD	1.71 (n=3)	1.29 (n=5)	17.15 (n=1)	9.86 (n=5)	28.01 (n=1)	30.94 (n=5)
Memistor (Widrow 1960, as claimed)	TTv2	0.63 (n=3)	0.73 (n=5)	3.24 (n=1)	2.86 (n=5)	10.75 (n=1)	8.99 (n=5)
Memistor (pessimistic)	SGD	32.58 (n=3)	–	41.52 (n=1)	–	47.26 (n=1)	–
Memistor (pessimistic)	TTv2	15.33 (n=3)	–	39.16 (n=1)	–	27.44 (n=1)	–
Pencil lead built today	SGD	23.05 (n=3)	–	43.92 (n=1)	–	42.36 (n=1)	–
Pencil lead built today	TTv2	11.72 (n=3)	–	37.39 (n=1)	–	21.98 (n=1)	–

Table 12: Main result (E3): gap to the exact-update baseline, mean and 95% t-interval over 5 seeds, paired by seed. MNIST and CIFAR in percentage points of test accuracy; LM in % of bits per byte. P = the whole interval is below the line (2 pp; 5%), F = wholly above, U = the interval contains the line. Every arm uses the FP validation learning rate.

Device	Algorithm	MNIST gap (pp)	CIFAR-10 subset gap (pp)	char-LM gap (%)
FP baseline (acc. %; bpb)		97.85 [97.79, 97.92]	60.39 [58.64, 62.14]	2.912 [2.822, 3.001]
Li-ECRAM (Tang 2018)	SGD	4.85 [4.73, 4.98] F	20.81 [18.06, 23.57] F	45.58 [31.52, 59.64] F
	TTv2	1.32 [0.49, 2.14] U	2.95 [0.94, 4.96] U	3.52 [0.86, 6.18] U
	c-TTv2	1.79 [0.94, 2.65] U	0.10 [-1.27, 1.47] P	-1.29 [-4.46, 1.87] P
	AGAD	0.86 [0.67, 1.06] P	1.06 [-1.05, 3.17] U	3.60 [-0.09, 7.30] U
MO-ECRAM (Kim 2019)	SGD	6.96 [6.60, 7.31] F	25.29 [22.15, 28.44] F	50.84 [36.24, 65.45] F
	TTv2	1.80 [1.68, 1.91] P	5.45 [2.15, 8.75] F	16.51 [13.17, 19.84] F
	c-TTv2	1.90 [1.81, 1.99] P	1.94 [-0.15, 4.03] U	15.68 [7.21, 24.14] F
	AGAD	0.49 [0.33, 0.66] P	1.39 [-0.31, 3.09] U	8.88 [6.10, 11.65] F
Protonic (Onen 2022)	SGD	3.07 [2.85, 3.29] F	15.77 [10.75, 20.79] F	40.82 [34.31, 47.33] F
	TTv2	1.04 [0.40, 1.69] P	2.13 [0.49, 3.77] U	3.64 [0.98, 6.30] U
	c-TTv2	0.74 [0.44, 1.05] P	0.08 [-2.57, 2.73] U	-0.84 [-4.30, 2.62] P
	AGAD	1.17 [0.73, 1.62] P	0.56 [-0.85, 1.98] P	3.82 [0.32, 7.33] U
W/YSZ/WO_x (Chen 2023)	SGD	8.25 [7.47, 9.02] F	36.82 [33.17, 40.47] F	50.67 [47.53, 53.81] F
	TTv2	1.48 [1.37, 1.60] P	10.59 [8.94, 12.24] F	21.17 [17.11, 25.24] F
	c-TTv2	1.75 [1.33, 2.17] U	9.87 [7.90, 11.84] F	21.23 [17.81, 24.66] F
	AGAD	1.08 [0.79, 1.37] P	17.55 [15.52, 19.58] F	26.59 [20.81, 32.38] F
Memistor (Widrow 1960, as claimed)	SGD	1.29 [1.12, 1.46] P	9.86 [2.80, 16.92] F	30.94 [25.31, 36.57] F
	TTv2	0.73 [0.28, 1.17] P	2.86 [-0.64, 6.35] U	8.99 [5.43, 12.54] F
	c-TTv2	0.49 [0.21, 0.77] P	1.32 [0.08, 2.55] U	6.59 [1.96, 11.23] U
	AGAD	1.29 [0.64, 1.94] P	2.06 [0.68, 3.44] U	7.76 [3.53, 11.99] U

E The original results (superseded)

The first version of this paper reported the experiments below, run on the original simulator. An independent review found that this simulator (i) drew the initialisation, the data order and all device randomness from one shared random stream, so that two arms of the same seed did not share their initial weights or their data order; (ii) moved the TTv2 and c-TTv2 accumulator straight to its symmetry point while charging 62 pulses it did not apply; and (iii) copied the AIHWKIT preset fields into a model with different bounds and no slope spread. The results are kept here unchanged, as preliminary results of that simulator; the revised experiments of Sections 4.2–4.4 replace them. The diagnostic of Appendix F measures how much each repair moves them.

The original headline readings were: plain SGD failed on every published device and task; the Li-ECRAM fit and the protonic device passed or were unresolved on all three tasks with a Tiki-Taka-family algorithm; the original width classifier labelled every arm FLAT (which, as the review noted, is not evidence of equivalence); and the original specification sheet was mostly "not reachable", which led to a post hoc degradation sheet relative to an already imperfect base (a CIFAR base gap of 2.39 pp plus 2 pp admits gaps up to 4.39 pp). The best original analog LM cell was 21.66 % worse in bits per byte than digital Adam (a perplexity ratio of 1.425).

F Revision history and response to the independent review

History. Version 1 (October 25, 2026) reported the experiments of Appendix E. An independent technical review (October 26, 2026) recommended major revision with thirteen findings. Version 2 (this paper) answers them; the full response, finding by finding, with the checks that

Table 13: Scale (E4): every arm uses its own validation-chosen learning rate (in parentheses) at every width; gap (pp for CIFAR, % for the LM), mean and 95% interval over 3 seeds paired with FP at its own learning rate. Verdict by the pre-registered rule (Section 4.3).

Task	Width	FP metric (lr)	Li-ECRAM c-TTv2	Li-ECRAM TTv2	Protonic c-TTv2	Protonic TTv2
CIFAR	16	55.70 (0.0003)	0.64 [-1.53, 2.82] (0.003)	1.86 [-0.64, 4.35] (0.001)	-2.13 [-7.14, 2.88] (0.003)	0.41 [-1.44, 2.26] (0.001)
CIFAR	32	60.15 (0.001)	-0.40 [-3.13, 2.33] (0.001)	2.12 [-1.66, 5.90] (0.001)	-1.88 [-6.35, 2.59] (0.003)	-0.21 [-5.27, 4.84] (0.003)
CIFAR	64	60.87 (0.0003)	-1.34 [-5.57, 2.89] (0.001)	1.11 [0.17, 2.05] (0.001)	-1.30 [-3.56, 0.96] (0.003)	0.33 [-2.43, 3.09] (0.001)
		verdict:	FLAT	FLAT	FLAT	FLAT
LM	64	3.193 (0.0001)	-0.55 [-8.58, 7.48] (0.0001)	-0.31 [-6.26, 5.63] (0.0003)	-7.21 [-11.77, -2.65] (0.0003)	-3.45 [-6.44, -0.46] (0.0003)
LM	128	2.881 (0.0001)	-0.09 [-7.23, 7.04] (0.0001)	-0.60 [-8.73, 7.53] (0.0003)	-6.38 [-12.53, -0.23] (0.0003)	-3.88 [-10.90, 3.14] (0.0003)
LM	256	3.100 (3e-05)	-13.73 [-14.66, -12.79] (0.0001)	-9.01 [-10.21, -7.82] (0.0001)	-12.97 [-13.57, -12.36] (0.0001)	-8.48 [-9.67, -7.29] (0.0001)
		verdict:	FLAT	SHRINKS	FLAT	SHRINKS

Table 14: Device specification sheet (E5) for TTv2: the weakest grid value of each parameter that keeps the gap under the line (2 pp CIFAR; 5% LM) with every other parameter at the protonic base (levels 1000, a 0.05, γ 0.2, c_{2c} 0.3, no drift, σ_r 0.02); in parentheses the interpolated crossing. †: the base itself fails and the value shown is the improvement needed; *: passes over the whole grid; n/r: not reachable on the grid. Last column: the joint specification (every axis at its threshold at once), mean gap over 3 seeds, round 1 or the tightened round 2.

Size	Levels	Asym. a	Nonlin. γ	Noise c_{2c}	Retention τ	Ref. err. σ_r	Joint spec
CIFAR 16	n/r	n/r	n/r	n/r	n/r	≤ 0 (0.0104)†	–
CIFAR 32	≥ 2000 (1488)†	n/r	n/r	≤ 0 (0.17)†	n/r	≤ 0 (0.0179)†	–
CIFAR 64	n/r	n/r	n/r	n/r	n/r	n/r	–
LM 64	≥ 500 (292)	≤ 0.2 (0.231)	≤ 0.2 (0.379)	≤ 1 (1.12)	$\geq$ 1e4 (7e3)	≤ 0.02 (0.0239)	r1: 4.74 pass
LM 128	≥ 1000 (612)	≤ 0.2 (0.21)	≤ 0.2 (0.281)	≤ 0.3 (0.727)	$\geq$ 1e4 (8e3)	≤ 0.02 (0.021)	r1: 2.45 pass
LM 256	n/r	n/r	n/r	n/r	n/r	n/r	–

confirmed or qualified each one, is `RESPONSE-TO-REVIEW.md` in the release. The revision plan was committed before any revision run (`PLAN-REVISION.md`); its deviations R1–R3 are recorded in `DEVIATIONS-PAPER.md`.

What was repaired.

1. **Random streams.** The initialisation, the data order, each tile's device population and the pulse/noise draws now have separate generators; every record carries the hashes of its logical initialisation and data order, and every arm of a seed shares them (checked). The old single stream is kept as a mode that replays the original simulator bit for bit.

2. **The reset.** The original reset moved A to its symmetry point and charged 62 pulses it never applied; applied through the device model those pulses leave 97.55 % of the displacement (from $u = 0.8$ the state only reaches 0.7835, against a symmetry point of 0.125; about 11,513 alternating pulses would be needed for a hundredfold reduction). The repaired pulse reset applies and counts every pulse; the ideal reset is reported only as a labelled variant.

3. **The AIHWKIT presets** are mapped one to one (shifted bounds, bound-scaled slopes, slope spread), and their pulse responses were compared with AIHWKIT's own (Section 4.1): the mapping is accepted.

4. **Measured, not assumed:** the clipping of the pulse probabilities and the lost update are recorded per layer.

The 8 checks of the repairs each fail on the old behaviour or a planted fault (8 faults; ALL_OK on the desk and on every pod).

Table 15: Degradation thresholds (descriptive, added after the one-at-a-time data were seen; DEVIATIONS-PAPER.md D1): the weakest grid value of each parameter whose gap stays within the line (2 pp CIFAR; 5% LM) of the protonic base device's own gap (column 3), all other parameters at the base; interpolated crossing in parentheses; * the whole grid stays within; n/r the nearest grid step already leaves the band.

Alg.	Size	Base gap	Levels	Asym. a	Nonlin. γ	Noise c_{2c}	Retention τ	Ref. err. σ_r
SGD	CIFAR 32	19.80	$\geq$ 1000 (520)	$\leq$ 0.05 (0.0813)	$\leq$ 0.2 (0.266)	$\leq$ 1 (1.3)	$\geq$ 1e4 (7e3)	$\leq$ 0.1 (0.15)
SGD	LM 128	39.85	$\geq$ 200 (143)	$\leq 0.4^*$	$\leq$ 0.2 (0.423)	$\leq 4^*$	$\geq$ 1e4 (3e3)	$\leq 0.5^*$
TTv2	CIFAR 16	4.03	$\geq 100^*$	$\leq$ 0.2 (0.204)	$\leq$ 0.5 (0.606)	$\leq$ 0.3 (0.789)	$\geq$ 1e5 (7e4)	$\leq$ 0.02 (0.0228)
TTv2	CIFAR 32	2.39	$\geq$ 500 (265)	$\leq$ 0.2 (0.209)	$\leq$ 0.5 (0.578)	$\leq$ 2 (2.31)	$\geq$ 1e5 (2e4)	$\leq$ 0.02 (0.0241)
TTv2	CIFAR 64	7.32	$\geq 100^*$	$\leq$ 0.2 (0.203)	$\leq 2^*$	$\leq$ 2 (2.62)	$\geq$ 1e5 (4e4)	$\leq$ 0.02 (0.0244)
TTv2	LM 64	3.18	$\geq$ 200 (130)	$\leq$ 0.2 (0.284)	$\leq$ 0.5 (0.717)	$\leq$ 2 (2.03)	$\geq$ 1e4 (5e3)	$\leq$ 0.02 (0.0326)
TTv2	LM 128	4.25	$\geq$ 200 (167)	$\leq$ 0.2 (0.276)	$\leq$ 0.5 (0.705)	$\leq$ 1 (1.67)	$\geq$ 1e4 (6e3)	$\leq$ 0.02 (0.028)
TTv2	LM 256	16.29	$\geq 100^*$	$\leq 0.4^*$	$\leq 2^*$	$\leq$ 2 (2.64)	$\geq$ 1e4 (4e3)	$\leq$ 0.02 (0.0351)

Table 16: Pairwise sensitivity (E5): the three largest interactions per task, interaction = gap(a,b) − [gap(a) + gap(b) − gap(base)].

Task	Pair	Gap(a,b)	Singles	Interaction
CIFAR	asym=0.1, tau_steps=1e3	46.64	1.82 + 33.96	13.25
CIFAR	asym=0.2, tau_steps=1e3	40.24	1.92 + 33.96	6.75
CIFAR	gamma=0.5, tau_steps=1e3	41.17	3.55 + 33.96	6.05
LM	c2c=1, tau_steps=1e3	76.94	5.27 + 33.74	42.18
LM	gamma=0.5, tau_steps=1e3	76.63	6.28 + 33.74	40.85
LM	asym=0.1, tau_steps=1e3	73.70	4.09 + 33.74	40.11

How much the repairs moved the original conclusions (diagnostic D1). Table 18 runs the original and the repaired simulator side by side at the original selections, 3 seeds, on MNIST and a 10-epoch CIFAR slice (234 runs).

- **The random streams** moved individual cells by up to 1.68 pp on MNIST and 3.89 pp on CIFAR (material, i.e. more than 1 pp or a label change, in 4 of 8 and 7 of 8 cells). With three seeds this is within the noise: the repaired FP-SGD alone spans 52.0–57.2 % on the CIFAR slice. The matched controls did not reduce the paired-gap spread here (median 1.78 against 0.76 pp).
- **The reset** moved cells by up to 1.38 pp on MNIST and 4.51 pp on CIFAR. The ideal reset gave no hidden advantage: a physical reset (pulse, alternating pairs or none) had an equal or smaller gap in 19 of 24 cells.
- **The mapping** moved Li-ECRAM by at most 0.52 pp on MNIST and 1.08 pp on CIFAR.
- **Unchanged:** plain SGD fails by far (MNIST 3.09–6.99 pp, CIFAR slice 10.35–17.87 pp).

Wording withdrawn or narrowed. "Near-digital" is not used. "Plain SGD fails on every device" became "every plain-SGD arm at the FP-selected learning rate exceeded the margin". "The gap does not grow with width" became the equivalence statement of Section 4.3. "Two device properties decide" and "a few hundred levels suffice" became conditional statements about the sweeps of Section 4.4. "The memistor lacked density, speed and energy, not accuracy" became "an optimistic historical-device scenario attained useful accuracy in this simulator". "32× today with the periphery counted" became the conditional projection of Section 5. "A bench replication"

Table 17: System energy per weight per row on the character LM (E6), in pJ: forward and backward MVMs at the measured 12.4 TOPS/W of [36], device pulses (simulated count × published or estimated energy per pulse), pulse lines and generation, and the TT-family reads. Ratio = H100 at its measured utilisation over the analog total; the range sets every input at its low or high end (records/ENERGY-SYSTEM.json).

Device	Algorithm	Pulses/w/row	MVM	Device	Lines	TT	Ratio	Range
Li-ECRAM (Tang 2018)	AGAD	0.034	0.323	0.0000	0.0013	0.00003	32.4	16.2–234
Li-ECRAM (Tang 2018)	c-TTv2	0.042	0.323	0.0000	0.0013	0.00003	32.3	16.2–234
Li-ECRAM (Tang 2018)	SGD	0.001	0.323	0.0000	0.0012	0.00000	32.4	16.2–234
Li-ECRAM (Tang 2018)	TTv2	0.038	0.323	0.0000	0.0013	0.00003	32.4	16.2–234
MO-ECRAM (Kim 2019)	AGAD	0.267	0.323	0.0003	0.0015	0.00003	32.3	16.2–232
MO-ECRAM (Kim 2019)	c-TTv2	0.339	0.323	0.0003	0.0015	0.00003	32.3	16.2–232
MO-ECRAM (Kim 2019)	SGD	0.007	0.323	0.0000	0.0013	0.00000	32.4	16.2–234
MO-ECRAM (Kim 2019)	TTv2	0.300	0.323	0.0003	0.0015	0.00003	32.3	16.2–232
Protonic (Onen 2022)	AGAD	0.026	0.323	0.0001	0.0038	0.00003	32.1	15.8–228
Protonic (Onen 2022)	c-TTv2	0.035	0.323	0.0001	0.0038	0.00003	32.1	15.8–228
Protonic (Onen 2022)	SGD	0.001	0.323	0.0000	0.0018	0.00000	32.3	16.1–233
Protonic (Onen 2022)	TTv2	0.033	0.323	0.0001	0.0037	0.00003	32.1	15.8–228
Memistor (Widrow 1960, as claimed)	AGAD	0.017	0.323	262122.1163	0.0012	0.00003	4e-05	2.69e-05–4.26e-05
Memistor (Widrow 1960, as claimed)	c-TTv2	0.022	0.323	323881.6451	0.0012	0.00003	3.24e-05	2.18e-05–3.45e-05
Memistor (Widrow 1960, as claimed)	SGD	0.002	0.323	30015.2982	0.0012	0.00000	0.000349	0.000235–0.000372
Memistor (Widrow 1960, as claimed)	TTv2	0.022	0.323	326250.3670	0.0012	0.00003	3.21e-05	2.16e-05–3.42e-05
W/YSZ/WO_x (Chen 2023)	AGAD	0.007	0.323	0.0000	0.0015	0.00003	32.3	16.2–233
W/YSZ/WO_x (Chen 2023)	c-TTv2	0.010	0.323	0.0000	0.0015	0.00003	32.3	16.2–233
W/YSZ/WO_x (Chen 2023)	SGD	0.000	0.323	0.0000	0.0013	0.00000	32.4	16.2–234
W/YSZ/WO_x (Chen 2023)	TTv2	0.009	0.323	0.0000	0.0015	0.00003	32.3	16.2–233

became “a proposed, unbuilt bench replication protocol”. “Every matrix is analog” became “the learned weight matrices use the device model; attention products and other operations are digital”.

Table 18: Diagnostic D1: mean gap to FP-SGD of the same simulator (pp, 3 seeds; P/F/U against 2 pp) at the original selections. Columns: the original simulator; the repaired random streams with the original ideal reset; then the reset replaced by the pulse reset, 31 alternating pulse pairs, or none; the published-style TTv2. The AIHWKIT-mapped Li-ECRAM row uses the pulse reset for TTv2 and c-TTv2. CIFAR here is a 10-epoch slice.

Task	Device	Alg.	original	seed-matched, ideal reset	pulse reset	alt. pairs	no reset	publishe
MNIST	Protonic-insp.	SGD	3.09F	4.58U				
MNIST	Protonic-insp.	TTv2	1.04U	1.60U	0.23P	0.66P	1.02P	0.99
MNIST	Protonic-insp.	c-TTv2	0.81P	0.62U	0.44P	0.97U	1.41P	
MNIST	Protonic-insp.	AGAD	1.21P	0.99P				
MNIST	Li-ECRAM (old map)	SGD	4.79F	6.47U				
MNIST	Li-ECRAM (old map)	TTv2	1.33U	1.19U	0.39P	0.36P	0.66P	1.43
MNIST	Li-ECRAM (old map)	c-TTv2	1.51U	0.98P	0.80P	0.68P	1.00P	
MNIST	Li-ECRAM (old map)	AGAD	0.96P	1.00P				
MNIST	Li-ECRAM (AIHWKIT map)	SGD		6.99U				
MNIST	Li-ECRAM (AIHWKIT map)	TTv2			0.40P			
MNIST	Li-ECRAM (AIHWKIT map)	c-TTv2			0.70P			
MNIST	Li-ECRAM (AIHWKIT map)	AGAD		0.57P				
CIFAR-10ep	Protonic-insp.	SGD	14.24F	10.35F				
CIFAR-10ep	Protonic-insp.	TTv2	5.28U	2.53U	2.04U	-0.83U	-1.97U	4.17
CIFAR-10ep	Protonic-insp.	c-TTv2	4.59U	3.41U	5.97U	-0.43U	0.65U	
CIFAR-10ep	Protonic-insp.	AGAD	-0.70P	-2.94U				
CIFAR-10ep	Li-ECRAM (old map)	SGD	17.69F	16.91F				
CIFAR-10ep	Li-ECRAM (old map)	TTv2	4.35F	2.51U	2.98U	0.57U	0.78U	5.41
CIFAR-10ep	Li-ECRAM (old map)	c-TTv2	6.08U	2.27U	1.63U	1.48U	0.99U	
CIFAR-10ep	Li-ECRAM (old map)	AGAD	0.39U	-1.34U				
CIFAR-10ep	Li-ECRAM (AIHWKIT map)	SGD		17.87F				
CIFAR-10ep	Li-ECRAM (AIHWKIT map)	TTv2			2.37U			
CIFAR-10ep	Li-ECRAM (AIHWKIT map)	c-TTv2			2.71U			
CIFAR-10ep	Li-ECRAM (AIHWKIT map)	AGAD		-1.02U				

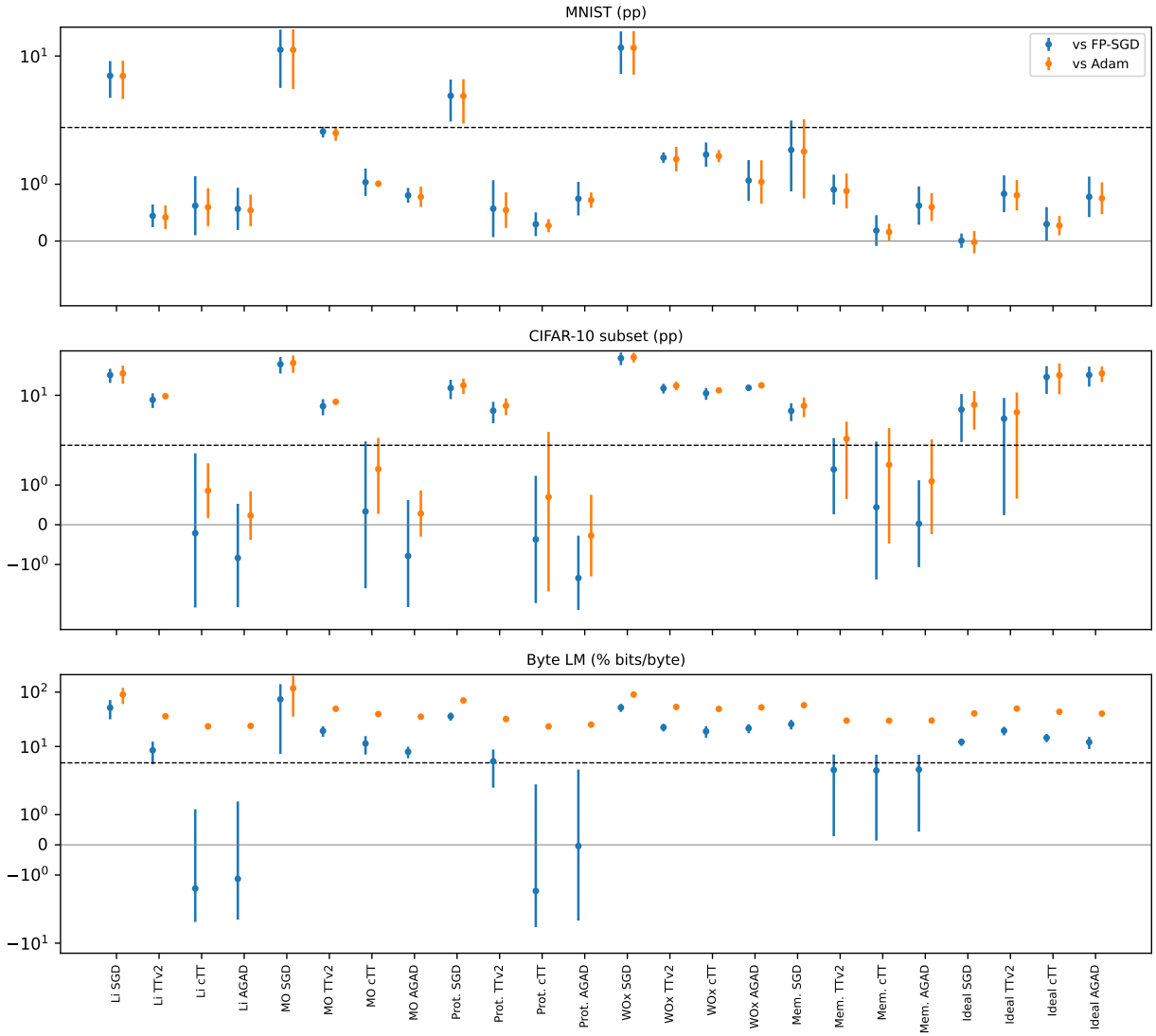


Figure 2: Repaired simulator: gap to FP-SGD (blue) and to digital Adam (orange) per device and algorithm, mean and 95 % interval over 5 seed-matched runs (symmetric-log axis); the dashed line is the gap line.

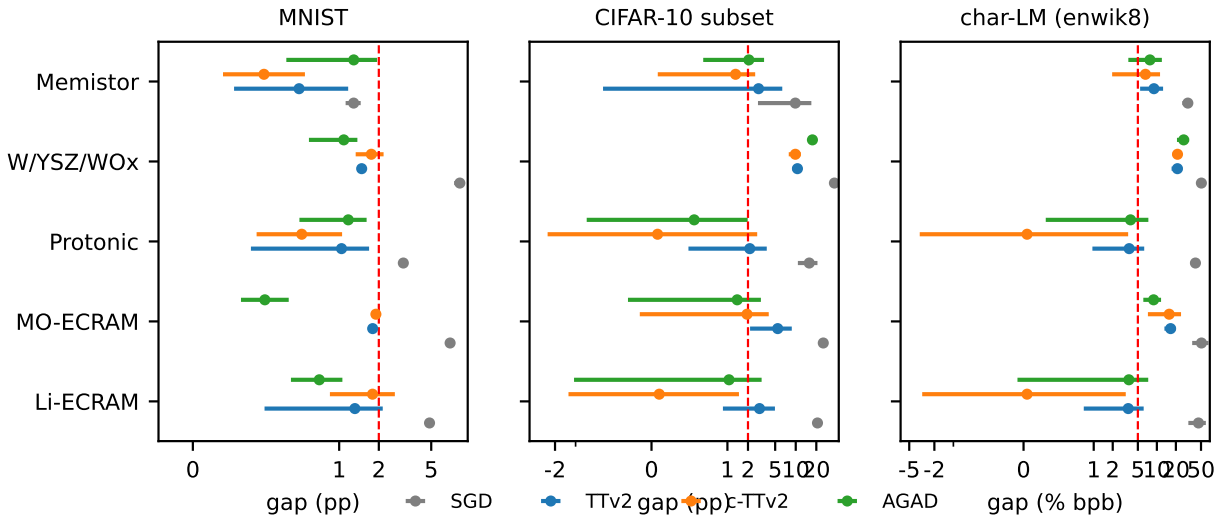


Figure 3: Original simulator: gap to the exact-update baseline (mean and 95% interval over 5 seeds; symmetric-log axis); the dashed line is the gap line.